

BNM-021
Introduction to Journalism
and Digital Media**Block****3****DIGITAL MEDIA AND SOCIETY****UNIT 11****Internet As A Medium** **163****UNIT 12****Theories of Digital Communication** **180****UNIT 13****Participatory Culture** **195****UNIT 14****Social Movements and Digital Media** **210**

BLOCK 3 DIGITAL MEDIA AND SOCIETY

In **Block 3, "Digital Media and Society,"** you will gain insights into the fundamental communication processes on digital platforms. We will explore the diverse types and tools employed in internet-based communication. Additionally, you will delve into the theoretical underpinnings of digital media and its communication patterns, examining individuals' engagement with digital platforms for personal and professional activities. Moreover, you will discover the significant role of digital media in mobilising public opinion and support for social and political change and its influence on policy decisions affecting the common population. This Block gives you a comprehensive understanding of digital media's impact on society and communication dynamics.

In **Unit 11, Internet As A Medium**, we will explore the Conceptual Framework of Cyberspace, uncover the Functional Dimensions of Cyberspace, and delve into the Characteristics of Cyberspace. Key highlights will be understanding the dynamics of Types of Internet-Based Communication, such as the Cohesive Force of Online Group Communication and the Communication Process in CMC. We will also explore Forms of Computer-Mediated Communication, including Impersonal CMC, Interpersonal CMC, and Hyperpersonal CMC, while immersing ourselves in the fascinating world of Virtual Communities.

In **Unit 12, Theories of Digital Communication**, we will explore the Shift in Theories of Communication from offline to online realms, examining Theories I: Sociological Perspective, which encompass concepts like Media Convergence, the Internet's impact on the Public Sphere, Remediation, and the emergence of the Information Society and Networked Publics. We will also delve into Theories II: Technological Perspective, including Network Society, Actor-Network Theory, Technological Determinism, and the Technological Shaping of Everyday Life.

Unit 13, Participatory Culture, delves into Henry Jenkins' groundbreaking concept of Participatory Culture, exploring its Sub-Genres and various Forms. Discover the empowering New Media Literacies (NML) Framework and examine the Applicability of Participatory Culture in real-life scenarios and the ever-evolving landscape of social media.

Unit 14, Social Movements and Digital Media, explore the Characteristics and Classification of Social Movements, followed by an in-depth understanding of Digital Media's Social Influence and its role in shaping Public Opinion. Discover the transformative power of Web 2.0 Tools and delve into the Types of Digital Media Activism, exploring Channels of Communication and Connective Action. This Unit uncovers Global Trends in Social Movements through Digital Media, including the impact of Hashtag Activism and intriguing Indian Experiences.

The discussions in this block about the various uses of digital platforms for exchanging information, ideas, opinions, and more in communication will provide a broader understanding of this digital medium.

UNIT 11 INTERNET AS A MEDIUM

Structure

- 11.0 Introduction
- 11.1 Learning Outcomes
- 11.2 Internet as a Medium of Communication
 - 11.2.1 Conceptual Framework of Cyberspace
 - 11.2.2 Functional Dimensions of Cyberspace
 - 11.2.3 Characteristics of Cyberspace
- 11.3 Types of Internet-Based Communication
 - 11.3.1 Dynamics of Communication Process in CMC
 - 11.3.2 Cohesive Force of Online Group Communication
- 11.4 Forms of Computer-Mediated Communication
 - 11.4.1 Impersonal CMC
 - 11.4.2 Interpersonal CMC
 - 11.4.3 Hyperpersonal CMC
- 11.5 Virtual Communities
- 11.6 Let Us Sum Up
- 11.7 Keywords
- 11.8 Further Readings
- 11.9 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

11.0 INTRODUCTION

In the first year, you have learnt the characteristics of various mass media entities such as the newspaper, radio, television, etc. In the case of newspapers, it has a limited lifecycle, and there is a geographical boundary in terms of its physical reach to its intended readers. Similarly, the electronic media - radio and television - have their limitations of reach of satellite footprints. However, electronic media is better placed as compared to print media. On the other hand, we now have a medium that transcends all these boundaries and limitations along with a worldwide reach irrespective of geopolitical governance. The Internet is emerging as a dominant medium in the mass media milieu. Interestingly, the Internet has multiple dimensions - you can use it for personal interactions and professional tasks.

Every mass media needs a channel and a medium. The channel is the carrier, while the medium facilitates the communication exchange process. In the case of the newspaper - print is the channel, and news stories of newspapers are the medium; in electronic media - electronic waves are channels, and electronic media programmes are its medium. Similarly, bandwidth and broadband are channels for the Internet, and information pockets are its medium.

In this Unit, you will learn about the concept of cyberspace, the basic structure of the Internet through which all the digital/online communication

process occurs and computer-mediated communication - a term used for the types of communication associated with Internet-based communication. One of the unique qualities of Internet communication is its ability to gather several users into specific areas - not physically, but gatherings based on common interests. Such gatherings are called virtual communities. You will learn about the multiple communication dimensions of the Internet in this Unit.

11.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After reading this Unit, you will be able to:

- understand the complex structure of cyberspace;
- explain the different forms of computer-mediated communication;
- state diverse patterns of Internet-based communication; and
- discuss the various dimensions of virtual/online communities.

11.2 INTERNET AS A MEDIUM OF COMMUNICATION

Information and Communication Technology (ICT) has given us a powerful communication tool through which we can merge many of our information and dissemination needs. About two decades back, we had only the mainstream media outlets for our society-wide communication purposes, which are still primarily vertical, i.e. we receive the messages in a top-down model and have limited participation options. The ICT platform has revolutionised how we communicate with one another and with society at large. Theoretically, this platform is cyberspace, including all digital and online media dimensions and platforms. Cyberspace provides a horizontal model of communication, and there is no hierarchy between the users. Every user can access the information, and at the same time, each user has the facility to communicate, not just with friends or relatives or colleagues, but with the entire globe. Such titanic changes in our communication platforms need to be understood academically.

11.2.1 Conceptual Framework of Cyberspace

Through computer or mobile, we usually immerse ourselves in various activities, and the platform through which we work and interact is called cyberspace. This term is not a new one. It was coined in 1984 by the science fiction writer William Gibson in his novel *Neuromancer*. While explaining the new term cyberspace, Gibson stated, “A consensual hallucination...a graphic representation of data abstracted from the back of every computer in the human system. Unthinkable complexity lines of light ranged in the non-space of the mind, clusters, and constellations of data. Like city lights receding.” We will see another definition from a famous scholar and pioneer in online community studies, Harold Rheingold. Rheingold's (1995) definition of cyberspace is "Conceptual space where words, human relationships, data, wealth, and power are manifested by people using CMC (Computer-mediated Communication) technology.”

The tools of ICT have created a platform for billions of people to gather and interact with each other. The core characteristics of fruitful interactions between humans are the primary components of cyberspace. One of the earlier scholars of cyberspace, Loader (1997), explains its unique features. He lists its characteristics as follows: "A computer-generated public domain which has no territorial boundaries or physical attributes and is in perpetual use. To date, its most potent manifestation is that matrix of electronic telecommunication and computer networks, usually referred to as the Internet, which links millions of people globally which is growing at a rapid rate daily and is taking new shape and direction as a consequence of the voluntary actions of its participants, and it is claimed that is not controlled by any single authority."

Communication through cyberspace is an extension of offline human-to-human interactions. We leave our physical presence, and we take different avatars in the online space. All these interactions are performed in the ICT-enabled and simulated environment.

In the virtual space, people still meet face-to-face but under new definitions of "meet" and "face." The cyber platform is the passage where physically separated people are bound together by common beliefs and practices. The essential element in cyberspatial social relations is the sharing of information. It is not sharing in the sense of transmission of information but binding communities in cyberspace. It is the ritual of information sharing that pulls it together.

Rather than incidental meetings, collective and common interest fuels the process of communication in cyberspace. Even before the invention of the Internet, Licklider and Taylor (1968) predicted that: "In most fields, they will consist of geographically separated members, sometimes grouped in small clusters, and sometimes working individually. There will be communities not of common location, but of common interest. In each geographical sector, the total number of users will be large enough to support extensive general-purpose information processing and storage facilities. Life will be happier for the individual who is in online because the people with whom he/she interacts most strangely will be selected more by the commonality of interests and goals than by accidents of proximity."

Interactivity is an essential element of new media. It eliminates the time barrier for users to access the contents conveniently anytime, anywhere. The time-shifting facility enhances a user's involvement in the online environment, and time becomes a crucial factor here. The virtual platform offers not only a multitude of topic areas but also the ability to participate at a convenient time. There is no weekly meeting to catch up after work. The meetings happen whenever the users have time to log in and read the new postings. This time-shifting allows users to ponder a particularly serious posting or article and write a coherent response. People from many time zones can participate in a discussion and have more control over their online experience, allowing them to participate at their convenience.

11.2.2 Functional Dimensions of Cyberspace

Cyberspace guarantees users the freedom to move along with the medium, which has dimensionality, continuity, curvature, density, and limits. It is a socially constructed and reconstructed space and essentially a re-conceived public sphere for social, political, economic, and cultural interaction. Cyberspace provides a new arena for public life in which a user can adopt any meaningful role like an author, public rhetorician, politician, or pundit, which is uncommon in the mass communication process. In cyberspace, says Benedikt (1991), "The common man and the information worker-cowboy or infocrat – can search, manipulate, create or control information directly; he can be entertained or trained, seek solitude or company, win or lose power indeed, can "live" or "die" as he will." cyberspace has two dimensions concerning the openness of its communication activity. It is "public space, at the same time it is private also," contends Fernback (1997), "where via email, two users can argue politics or fall in love, or several users on a private list server can strategise a meeting or discuss the finer points of a classroom lecture."

The CMC users' relationships can range from the cold, professional encounter to the hot, intimate rendezvous. Rheingold (1995), while describing routine activities of this medium, says a user can "Exchange pleasantries and argue, engage in intellectual discourse, conduct commerce, exchange knowledge, share emotional support, make plans, brainstorm, gossip, feud, fall in love, find friends and lose them, play games, flirt, create a little high art and even engaged in a lot of idle talks. People ... do just about everything people do in real life, but we leave our bodies behind. You cannot kiss anybody, and nobody can punch you in the nose, but a lot can happen within those boundaries. To the millions who have been drawn into it, the richness and vitality of computer-linked cultures are attractive, even addictive."

Cyberspace is a multi-faceted environment where one can find immensely varied, amalgamated, and combined social relations. Fernback (1997) gives a detailed account of the inner view of cyberspace: "It is a repository for collective memory - it is popular culture, it is narrative created by its inhabitants that remind us who we are, it is life as lived and reproduced in pixels and virtual texts. It is sacred and profane, and it is workspace and leisure space; it is a battleground and a nirvana, it is real and virtual; it is ontological and phenomenological. Cyberspace is an arena of power; CMC users act every day on the assumption that the tyranny of geography can be overcome within cyberspace. It is smaller, more intimate, and almost more imaginable than "the public," which can no longer fit into a stadium."

The revolution in global networked communications has given rise to a new generation of social technologies, including mechanisms for forming and cultivating interpersonal relationships. The global reach of the Internet not only facilitates communication among members of existing distributed groups and teams but also provides a medium for forming and cultivating new relationships by providing virtually instantaneous access to thousands of potential contacts with compatible interests and spheres of expertise.

Urbanisation and industrialisation have resulted in a mass society in the urban context where the social relationship is highly fragmented. CMC is acting like a new cohesive force to build an online relationship. As Jones (1998) argues, "CMC allows us to customise our social contacts from fragmented communities and to plan, organise and make efficient and social contacts." Linda Harasm (1993) found that social communication is a primary component of CMC and can organise thoughts about using CMC around social situations rather than working areas.

Even though CMC facilitates tremendous information exchange power, it has its inadequacies. One prominent negative feature, cited by most CMC scholars, is that CMC occurs in cyberspace mostly with letters and words. This textual communication filters out demographic and socio-economic information about the user, such as sex and social status, which also limits relational meaning.

11.2.3 Characteristics of Cyberspace

Compared to face-to-face communication, which is considered the communication standard against which all others are found to be inferior, a CMC user cannot hear intonation that signals a joke or see puzzled expressions that convey confusion. Also, users often need help coordinating informal discussions due to the lack of information feedback, the absence of social influence cues, and depersonalisation due to the lack of non-verbal involvement. Research on spoken conversational interaction shows that simultaneous feedback plays a vital role in signalling listenership, timing turn-taking effectively, and maintaining continuous interaction. Also, the absence of simultaneous feedback may result in discontinuity and/or overlap within turn sequences, as well as generally making it more difficult for message producers to tailor their messages to respond to recipients' interests and needs. When the relevant responses are disrupted, CMC users may experience difficulty tracking sequential exchanges, making the interaction fragmented.

To theorise this impersonal communication pattern in 1987, Culnan and Markus described it as the "cues filtered out" theory (also called "reduced cues"), which posits that the computer has a "low social presence" because it filters out important aspects of communication that participants in the face-to-face communication are privy to (paralanguage, pitch, stress, tempo, volume), leaving a conversation in a "social vacuum."

Ried (1991) exposes the failings of CMC in this regard as follows: "Words, as we use them in speech, fail to express what they really mean once they are deprived of the subtleties of speech and the non-verbal cues that we assume will accompany it. It is only the meanings of sentences that become problematic in computer-mediated communication. The standards of behaviour that are normally decided upon by verbal-users are not clearly indicated when information is purely textual."

To take this argument further, Mackinnon (1995) states how CMC inadequacies overwhelm its success compared to the offline world social structure. "Lacking physical reality, [CMC] users must create an explicit

written language to convey meaning, emotion, physical qualities, and action. As a society based on language, it relies heavily on symbols, analogy, and metaphor to recreate or transfer physical matter and actions from the external world. But as these recreations are merely metaphors for, or “analogues” of, their physical counterparts, [CMC] can never be a mirror image of the external world.”

Another striking feature of networked CMC environments is the anonymity crisis. A user potentially enjoys opportunities to conceal his/her real offline identity in the online world. Compared with other forms of communication, participants of CMC have substantially more control over their self-presentation. In face-to-face communication, each person involved in the communication process confronts the other, and obviously, they reveal their identities. In a telephonic mobile conversation, the speaker's gender, to some extent their age, and emotional reactions like fear, anxiety, happiness, and tonal difference help to gauge varied qualities of semiotic reference to a speaker's message framework.

Nevertheless, in the CMC, the textual form of message sharing bears a bare minimal imprint of social identities. The online message has the potential to confuse identity, which is counterproductive to those arguing that the content of messages reveals much about the nature of speakers (Lee, 1997).

The use of false identities, often of different sex, is widespread in electronic communities. Rheingold's (1995) comparison of the offline and online worlds is an apt example. "The physical world is a place where the identity and position of the people you communicate with are well known, fixed, and highly visual. In cyberspace, everybody is in the dark. We can only exchange words with each other - no glances or shrugs or ironic smiles. Even the nuances of voice and intonation are stripped away. On top of the technology-imposed constraints, we who populate cyberspace deliberately experiment with fracturing traditional notions of identity by living as multiple simultaneous personae in different virtual neighbourhoods.”

The anonymity or the lack of clarity, single authorship condition has marred online-based research to a great extent. A researcher can never be sure of the demographics of site users, and according to the current level of technological improvements, there is no possible way to obtain identity confirmation. Most computer interfaces are either not designed to allow the user to question data validity or are designed so that anyone may change that data with moderate technical skill. Once there is a new set of social norms for validating computer information, there will be some uneasiness over the trust quotient of computer networks.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1. Explain the concept of time shifting with suitable examples.

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2. Write about the pros and cons of cyberspace.

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3. Compare and contrast face-to-face communication with online discussions.

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Activity – 1

Use any internet archives to visit the earlier generation USENET-based online community and observe its past activities. Based on your observation, write a brief report [400 words].

11.3 TYPES OF INTERNET-BASED COMMUNICATION

The World Wide Web (WWW) has re-arranged the basic tenet of a common person's communication activities in his/her day-to-day life. Even though electronic communication is not an alternative to face-to-face (F2F) communication, Internet technology has considerably overcome the time and space barriers between two communication points. Each fabric of social structure has established a meaningful connection with ICTs, ranging from e-business, online learning, e-governance, and e-shopping to online social movements.

The interconnection of multiple components of human society has increased information flow, cutting across national boundaries towards creating a "global village", as predicted by Marshal McLuhan.

Various forms and communication processes can be carried out on the Internet in the fastest and cheapest ways and, more importantly, the widest reach. The telegraph detached the concept of transportation of communication from one point to another; the Internet went one step ahead and abolished the middle person to deliver messages directly and instantaneously. Moreover, it has facilitated the free exchange of information, unfettered and unhindered by any censorship, which is another essential feature. The Internet profoundly impacts the day-to-day activities of the entire human social spectrum.

In the Internet medium, a user can explore various possibilities independently. McLaughlin (1995) explained that it is an opportunity to "exchange electronic mail, transfer files, search databases, and retrieve information from remote libraries, take part in real-time conferences, run software on distance computers, and participate in discussion groups on varied topics."

Computer-mediated communication is one type of communication facilitated by computer technologies. It is defined as "synchronous or asynchronous electronic mail and computer conferencing, by which senders encode in text messages that are relayed from sender's computers to receivers." There are two distinct types of CMCs existing over computer technologies: synchronous and asynchronous, and the difference between the two CMCs is temporal. Synchronous CMC is produced when communication occurs simultaneously between two or more users, as in any normal telephonic, face-to-face, or live video conferencing conversation. Asynchronous CMC is produced when communication is not simultaneous.

The most prevalent asynchronous CMC is electronic mail, where a user can drop and receive a message at his/her convenience. Another popular category is social media postings (non-live messages), where the sender and receiver use a commonplace to read and post messages. In both cases, time is not a constraint for sending and reading the messages. On the other hand, in synchronous CMC, both the partners of the communication process must be available online. One-to-one or group, text/audio/video-based chat/discussion via messenger software are popular forms of synchronous CMC.

Whether synchronous or asynchronous, "The CMC, it is claimed, will

1. create opportunities for education and learning;
2. create new opportunities for participatory democracy;
3. establish countercultures on an unprecedented scale;
4. ensnarl the already difficult legal matters concerning privacy, copyright, and ethics; and
5. restructure man and machine interaction" (Jones, 1998).

Initially, it was thought that CMC technology would overcome time and space barriers without having a centralised control authority to monitor the system. Besides, the universal spread of CMC has provided a facility to access unlimited data and reach other people. In the context of CMC's capacity to create a global pattern of linkage, Lee (1997) elaborates on its potential power as follows: "The information highway makes possible unprecedented forms of mediated communications. Never before has there been a means of communication which have provided so many individuals with the ease and ability to engage in instantaneous, interactive communications with a broad and diverse public. The import of these new technologies, however, lies not simply in the novel forms of communication. What is also of profound significance is the ways in which these communicative possibilities lead to new types of identities and social relationships. Previously unimaginable, millions of individuals are increasingly interacting across time and space and forming mutual bonds

with others, most of whom they neither have met nor will ever meet face-to-face."

Due to its global reach and rich multilingual context, the Internet has the potential to influence social relations. Unlike traditional mass media, the online medium has an open architecture that restricts the efforts of legal authorities to regulate its activities. This, in turn, has facilitated greater freedom and space for its users and members to express their feelings on the net on issues that interest them. Thus, the Internet provides a technological infrastructure for CMC across both time and space to create a group communication environment in which virtual co-presence is established due to an individual's online interactions. This has created a potential platform for virtual communities to flourish on the net. However, interconnected computers do not by themselves provide a congenial space for a group of people to float an online community in cyberspace; it is necessary to have sufficient human relationships.

11.3.1 Dynamics of Communication Process in CMC

Irrespective of its modality of presence, online or offline, overlapping with offline, any meaningful discussion in the CMC forum is determined by the quality of communication and its message. The very nature of CMC has abolished social and cultural domination in group dynamics. The computer medium inhibits users from transferring the social structures to CMC, and this inhibition results from the absence of or limitations on physical proximity, face-to-face interaction, and non-verbal use.

People with strong articulation skills rather than social status play a dominant role in the text-based community. While analysing the social role of CMC technologies, Jones (1998) indicates two prominent usages: "Computers cut across or break down boundaries and break down hierarchies." Similarly, Perrolle (1991) outlines the power and status structure of the communication process in the CMC milieu: "Computer-mediated communication changes the nature of conversations between people. Research indicates that it alters the social norms governing conversation by removing elements of emotion and social control. It also provides the possibility of equal participation by obscuring the visual and verbal distinctions of status that gives high-ranking or aggressive people an advantage in face-to-face speech. Designs for cooperative work seek computer network support for circumstances in which opportunities for participation are enhanced and opportunities for one speaker to control another are reduced. But computer-mediated communication can also embody inequalities in social relationships and can limit conversational participation."

Factors like power and social status are not meaningful in online activities. The virtual space in which people meet is neutral ground. Cyberspace belongs to everyone, yet no one. The conversation is the primary activity there, but it favours people who are good with their words rather than just *fast* with their mouths. The conversation is often much more thought out, and it is easier for everyone to express their opinion and not be dominated by one or two loud people. In an online community, every participant is in charge of his/her involvement. Online communities are entirely participant-driven, and

the conversation is about what a member has written.

A group of human beings settled in a new environment tends to formulate norms and values for the smooth conduct of the social processes of their new community. Likewise, virtual members also establish group-specific rules in the online environment. Participants in CMC develop forms of expression that enable them to communicate social information and to create and codify group-specific meanings. Conformity with created norms also serves to socially negotiate group-specific identities, form relationships and organise interaction, and maintain desirable social climates. In CMC, as in real life, relationships take time to build. The social information not available in the immediacy of face-to-face context can be gained verbally through computer-mediated interaction; the social penetration process takes longer. People who meet online may then take that relationship offline if an opportunity arises.

There could be several reasons for a member to be associated with a virtual world. The loss of casual gathering places in our lives is one of the reasons why many people have turned to virtual spaces where they can achieve some feeling of community. The virtual environment fulfils a unique need for many people that they cannot find elsewhere in their lives. Although many special interest groups exist in the physical community, there is not always a forum located nearby to discuss the particular topic in which each person is interested. Virtual platforms provide a forum for such discussions.

There is no topic under the sun left aside by these communities. Due to its worldwide reach, a group of enthusiasts joins together to stay abreast of the latest developments in their area of choice by having meaningful discussions on digital forums. Suppose the discussion area is important and sensitive, where a cross-section of human society has a sentimental touch. In that case, it corners massive attention from a relatively large number of members.

11.3.2 Cohesive Force of Online Group Communication

In cyberspace, people can roam freely and create a virtual community far from the legal and nation-state purview. It comprises members distributed in all 24 time zones, which are equal in all possible social spheres regarding shared belief in the principles of free speech, individualism, equality, and open access.

Ananda Mitra (1997) applies theoretical concepts of offline community to online communities and states that the online community setup has a profound impact on the way we interact and the way we are going to interact with one another. Further, he adds that "In the electronic age, particularly in the age of the Internet, the organisation of human activities has become more complex with the availability of fast, efficient, and powerful means of communication that can have a significant impact on the way we organise the communities we live in and interact with. Moreover, that effect need not be restricted to specific geographic spaces but can be widespread as the tentacles of computer-mediated communication (CMC) reach across the globe."

With this background information about the community and its rules that govern people's interaction, it is clear that replicating existing offline cannons

does not apply to virtual communities. At the same time, it is essential to note that the emergence of online communities based on different principles does not occur in a social vacuum.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1. Differentiate the communication process between synchronous and asynchronous modes of online interactions.

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2. Differentiate the basic features of an online community from the offline community.

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Activity – 2

Enrol yourself in an online community that exists through any popular social media platform. Observe its activities for a fortnight, and give your assessment - reflecting your understanding of the theoretical concepts [400 words].

11.4 FORMS OF COMPUTER-MEDIATED COMMUNICATION

One of the classic studies in the area of CMC was done by Joseph Walther (1996, 2015), in which he classified three types of CMC - 1] Impersonal CMC, 2] Interpersonal CMC, and 3] Hyper-personal CMC. These three-forms of CMCs show the historical growth of research and understanding of the human relationship through computer-mediated interactions. The advent of technology has played an equally significant role in shaping and theorising human relationships through CMC.

11.4.1 Impersonal CMC

In the early stages of CMC, around the early 90s in the last century, available technologies mostly allowed rich-text-based communications between people, like emails, text chat, and Usenet groups. Many early-stage research findings discussed the scenario of 'scant social information' and its implications in computer-mediated human communications in which non-verbal cues are minimal, if not absent. However, many early-stage findings argued that the group tasks had better achievement rates in the impersonal

CMC due to the lack of space in establishing social power structure in the textual CMC. However, in further research findings, the impersonal CMC concept was challenged in multiple dimensions.

11.4.2 Interpersonal CMC

The interpersonal CMC mainly equates online discussion with face-to-face communication settings. In interpersonal CMC, all CMC participants use all efforts to replicate the f2f settings and various cues commonly adapted in interpersonal CMC (smileys are some of the adapted cues in interpersonal CMC). Since the efforts are employed to equate to f2f, usually, interpersonal CMC requires more time to meet the expected outcome of communication settings.

11.4.3 Hyperpersonal CMC

In the hyper-personal CMC environment, each stage of communication tools - sender, channel, receiver, and feedback - are employed carefully and optimally, more importantly, selective self-presentation in order to create an idealised perspective about the sender by the receiver. Since the communication between the participants is a continuous process, channel-receiver feedback is conducted continuously in order to maintain the idealised perspectives and impressions of each other.

11.5 VIRTUAL COMMUNITIES

An online or virtual community is where people gather together and exchange messages through digital networks. More importantly, these people gather into virtual communities based on their areas of common interest, and they may come from different geographical locations. Even many members might not have met each other in their lifetime.

Harold Rheingold (1996), considered the father of virtual community studies, defines virtual communities as "Cultural aggregations that emerge when enough people bump into each other often enough in cyberspace. It is a group of people who may or may not meet one another face-to-face and who exchange words and ideas through the mediation of computer bulletin boards and networks. We do everything that people do when people get together, but we do it with words on computer screens leaving our bodies behind."

A virtual community has its advantages compared to its counterpart in the offline world. CMC will do, by way of electronic pathways, what cement roads could not do - connect us rather than isolate us, put us at the controls of a "vehicle", and yet not detach us from the rest of the world. Unlike face-to-face interaction, in which relationships are initiated, and topics of mutual interest are sought, Internet users can go directly to the topics that interest them and pursue interaction with like-minded people.

In furthering the concept of the virtual community, Rheingold puts forth the very purpose of online meetings. He proclaims it as "social aggregations that emerge from the [Internet] when enough people carry on those public discussions long enough, with sufficient human feeling, to form webs of personal relationships in cyberspace."

Unlike the traditional mass communication setup, where central authority controls the selection and production of messages consumed by millions, virtual communities offer a more democratic apparatus where access is broadly distributed and brings the option of interaction, offering new possibilities for community formation in the online platform. In electronic communities, a set of shared practices helps produce conditions similar to traditional communities outside of the realm of computers and virtual spaces defined by the "bit"-based technology of computers. Here, the community becomes central because technology has now provided the ability to communicate across boundaries and has removed limitations that the traditional community imposed.

Cyberspace technology's support for the formation of virtual communities is a mere structural one, and it does not have any meaningful role in sustaining the group for an extended period. Human interaction and the spirit of commonality are vital to fostering virtual communities. The commonality that holds virtual community intact is the subject line criterion of togetherness, a feeling of connectedness that confers a sense of belonging.

Interconnected computers do not by themselves provide congenial space for a group of people to float an online community in cyberspace. Moreover, virtual communities of interest can be formed only if everyone adheres to a standard set of guidelines for organising the groups, subgroups, and topics. According to Baym (1995), temporal structure, external contexts, systems infrastructure, groups' purposes, and participant and group characteristics are the most salient pre-existing forces in developing the computer-mediated community.

Even though members of virtual communities come from diverse geographical points, they share certain common traits. According to Lave and Wenger, participants of virtual communication can be classified into Peripheral (i.e. Lurker) – external, unstructured participation; Inbound (i.e. Novice) – a newcomer interested in the community and heading towards full participation; Insider (i.e. Regular) – fully committed community participant; Boundary (i.e. Leader) – a leader, sustains membership participation and brokers interactions; and Outbound (i.e. Elder) – in the process of leaving the community as a result of new relationships, new positions, new and outlook.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1. Explain the relevance of impersonal CMC in contemporary social media-dominated online scenarios.

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2. Discuss the emergence of virtual communities on the Facebook platform.

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Activity – 3

Visit any YouTube-based channel with more than 1000 subscribers and analyse the type of participants it has. Categorise them as per the points mentioned on the previous page.

11.6 LET US SUM UP

In this Unit, we have discussed the concepts related to cyberspace. This online platform exists in digital networks through which we communicate our ideas, using various media elements such as text, photos, smiley, audio-video content, etc. Unlike the offline world's social hierarchy, we have gone through the conceptual frameworks of cyberspace in which knowledge matters in digital networks. Similarly, we have discussed various formats of computer-mediated communication - synchronous and asynchronous, and different forms of CMC - impersonal, interpersonal, and hyper-personal. With the help of digital networks and computer-media communication, an online community emerges by aggregating like-minded and common interest-oriented people gathered in cyberspace. This human settlement is a unique form of social relationship that exists within ourselves.

11.7 KEYWORDS

Asynchronous CMC is the opposite of synchronous CMC, yet another form of Computer-media communication. This form of CMC happens with time constraints, which means that the people involved in this communication process are not necessarily available in real-time. The sender and receiver exchange information at different times. There is a delay in feedback and responses. Email-based communication is one of the examples of asynchronous CMC.

Computer-Mediated Communication: A human communication process of sharing words and ideas between people over digital networks. The information exchange may be on a real-time basis and delayed patterns, and the communication process uses multiple media elements.

Cyberspace: It is an electronic space or medium that exists in the networks of various networks. Cyberspace facilitates communication between human beings through computing devices and within/between computing devices. This conceptual electronic space is not constrained by distance and physical limitations.

Online/Virtual Community: There are many names associated with Online Community/Virtual Community/Digital Community/Web Community - but

all refer to a group of people who aggregate themselves based on common interest, and they may come from any geographical place but use mostly asynchronous modes of computer-mediated communication. In the longer run, these communities tend to develop their social norms for their members.

Synchronous CMC: It is a form of Computer-mediated communication where the information exchange happens in real-time, which means the people involved at both ends of the communication process should be available in the computing networks but not necessarily in the same location. Virtual/video conferencing is one of the examples of synchronous CMC.

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11.9 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

1. Two types of communication processes are part of a digital platform - synchronous and asynchronous. Asynchronous communication does not require people to be involved in real-time while exchanging ideas and information. Interactivity is an important element of new media. It eliminates the time barrier for users to access the contents conveniently anytime, anywhere. The time-shifting facility enhances a user's involvement in the online environment; hence, time is a crucial factor here. The virtual platform offers not only a multitude of topic areas but also the ability to participate at a convenient time. There is no weekly meeting to catch up after work. Email is one of the popular examples of the asynchronous mode of computer-mediated communication.
2. Cyberspace is an electronic conceptual platform that exists in a network of networks. This platform facilitates communication exchanges between people, people, and digital devices and among digital devices. The main advantage of cyberspace is that it cuts the physical distance between two communicating people, irrespective of their time zones. The quantum of the exchange of information will be huge and equal, and it might be in multiple modes of communication. The central negative dimension of cyberspace is that it reduces the exchange of non-verbal cues that might alter the length of the discussion and the complete exchange of ideas.
3. Face-to-face communication takes the topmost position in any ranking of communication settings. It is not comparable to any other alternative mode of personal interaction. However, cyberspace has provided a platform to interact with each other to overcome physical constraints and different geographical locations. F2F is rich in cues and non-verbal communication, which strongly influences the course of communication between the persons involved. It is instantaneous, and the person involved takes a quick turn in his/her role. Whereas in computer-mediated communication, particularly in the synchronous CMC, there is a scope for instantaneous feedback and role change, personal communication over cyberspace tends to lack non-verbal cues and signs, which might delay the information exchange.

Check Your Progress 2

1. Synchronous-based computer-mediated communication is being carried out on a real-time basis. The people involved in these activities must be present in the process in their respective places and participate in the LIVE communication exchange. Whereas in asynchronous mode, as the name suggests, the communication process does not require the active presence of its participants.
2. An online community is a collection of people from diverse geographical backgrounds. However, they join the online platform (be it a social media group member or email listserv group member) based on their

common interest. In the online community, there are no physical or time constraints. In the case of an offline community, it is primarily the location specified, and members usually come from the nearest places. However, the common interest could also be a binding factor here. Regular meetings or gatherings are the few options available to them to meet each other, and time is the biggest constraint here.

Check Your Progress 3

1. Impersonal CMC refers to the communication exchanges that happen entirely in textual mode, which generally lacks non-verbal behavioural cues. These cues are crucial in routine face-to-face communication settings. Hence, impersonal CMC tends to be inferior to f2f settings. The scholar Joseph Walther gave critical inputs on impersonal CMC; however, later research findings gave critical assessments. In contemporary settings, the impersonal CMC is rarely noticed due to many technological advancements - audio-video conferences, smiley expressions, and more multimedia-oriented online information exchanges that give ample scope to replicate non-verbal cues.
2. Virtual communities can exist on Facebook platforms - either the users are following an individual or a particular page or a group (it can be private as well as public; some of them are unmoderated while most are moderated). Being members of this group or page or an individual page, they tend to exchange ideas with other members; over some time, the group or page or member of an individual develops its social norms. Thus, a virtual community on the Facebook platform is possible.

UNIT 12 THEORIES OF DIGITAL COMMUNICATION

Structure

- 12.0 Introduction
- 12.1 Learning Outcomes
- 12.2 Intersection of the Digital with Society and Culture
- 12.3 Shift in Theories of Communication: From Offline to Online
- 12.4 Theories I: Sociological Perspective
 - 12.4.1 Media Convergence
 - 12.4.2 The Internet and the Public Sphere
 - 12.4.3 Remediation
 - 12.4.4 Information Society
 - 12.4.5 Networked Publics
- 12.5 Theories II: Technological Perspective
 - 12.5.1 Network Society
 - 12.5.2 Actor-Network Theory
 - 12.5.3 Technological Determinism
 - 12.5.4 The Technological Shaping of Everyday Life
 - 12.5.5 Cyborg Manifesto and Critical Posthumanism
- 12.6 Let Us Sum Up
- 12.7 Keywords
- 12.8 Further Readings
- 12.9 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

12.0 INTRODUCTION

The digital revolution has transformed the ways in which we communicate, socialise and live our experiences on an everyday basis. Along with our individual lives, the domains of media and the cultural, social, economic, and political spheres have changed considerably. The playfield of media forms, content, and infrastructure has also shifted from analogous to digital, along with media production, information dissemination, market regulation, and media ownership patterns. The concepts of time and space have also collapsed along with the traditions of media forms.

Therefore, overall, our lived realities have encapsulated and aligned with a digital presence at the individual, micro, and macro levels. This has also influenced the academic realm and theoretical frameworks to look at media.

Traditional media theories have converged into the online space, introducing new concepts, constructs, and theories related to the digital sphere. The digitality, interactivity, hyperreality, dispersal, and virtuality of online media have also been reflected in the academic narratives of media's relationship with us in the socio-cultural aspects of life. In this unit, we will bring to light

the theories of communication in the digital sphere from the vantage point of an individual, society, and technology at large.

12.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After working through this unit, you will be able to:

- demonstrate the shift in the theoretical framework of media;
- illustrate the concepts and theories of digital communication;
- elaborate on the sociological theories of digital media; and
- underscore the technological intervention in the theoretical framework of media.

12.2 INTERSECTION OF THE DIGITAL WITH SOCIETY AND CULTURE

The intervention of digital media in our society and culture has had profound transformations in our everyday life, whether it is a sense of self, identity curation, politics of age and gender in families and the society at large, consumption patterns, or the connections between the global and local.

The networks with spaces and relationships of the home have been redefined. Our everyday popular culture and experiences have transiently shifted to gaming and mobile phones. Our every day relationships and environments also shape the nature and adoption of new media technologies and vice versa. The developing fields of technologically mediated communication and production that have shaped the nature of our everyday relationships and environments would include:

- ***Computer-mediated communications:*** email, chat rooms, avatar-based communication forums, voice image transmissions, the World Wide Web, blogs, etc., social networking sites, and mobile telephony.
- ***New ways of distributing and consuming*** media texts are characterised by interactivity and hypertextual formats- the World Wide Web, CD, DVD, Podcasts, and the various platforms for computer games.
- ***Virtual ‘realities’:*** simulated environments and immersive representational spaces
- ***A whole range of transformations and dislocations of established media*** (in, for example, photography, animation, television, journalism, film, and cinema).

The digital has also revolutionised how we experience culture with digital artefacts, virtual museums, digital video and music libraries, digital religious practices, etc.

The advent of the internet was coincidental with the notions of postmodernity, globalisation, the information age, and decentralised power structures, which ultimately led to the emergence of a 'new era'. The emergence of new media is, thus, an epoch-making phenomenon within the realm of a much larger landscape of social, technological, and cultural change, often seen as part of a new technoculture.

12.3 SHIFT IN THEORIES OF COMMUNICATION: FROM OFFLINE TO ONLINE

The advent of the internet has had a significant impact on media theories. Here are some ways in which media theories have changed with the rise of the internet:

- ***The democratisation of media:*** The internet has enabled anyone to create and share content, leading to a more democratised media landscape. This has challenged traditional media models, which were based on a few large media corporations controlling the distribution of information.
- ***The rise of participatory culture:*** The internet has facilitated the rise of participatory culture, where consumers are no longer passive recipients of media messages but active participants in creating and sharing content. This has led to the development of new theories, such as Henry Jenkins' Theory of Participatory Culture.
- ***The fragmentation of media audiences:*** The internet has made it easier for people to access a wide range of media content, leading to the fragmentation of media audiences. This has challenged traditional media models based on the assumption that a mass audience for a particular media product exists.
- ***The importance of networked communication:*** The internet has facilitated networked communication, where people are connected to each other through digital networks. This has led to the development of new theories, such as Manuel Castells' Theory of Networked Society.
- ***The impact of digital technologies:*** The internet has facilitated the development of new digital technologies, such as social media and mobile devices, which have profoundly impacted media consumption patterns. This has led to the development of new theories, such as Nicholas Carr's Theory of the Shallows, which argues that the internet is rewiring our brains and making it harder for us to concentrate for extended periods.

Therefore, the emergence of the internet has challenged traditional media models and has led to the development of new theories that better reflect the current media landscape. While the advent of the internet has led to the development of new media theories, some traditional media theories have also transitioned and adapted to the digital age.

In the context of the *Agenda Setting Theory*, it originally proposes that media has the power to shape the public's perception of what is important by highlighting certain issues over others. The introduction of the internet has led to a proliferation of news sources, and traditional news outlets are no longer the sole gatekeepers of information. However, research has shown that social media platforms such as Twitter can still influence the public agenda by amplifying certain issues and creating a sense of urgency around them.

Similarly, the *Uses and Gratifications Theory* suggests that people consume media to fulfil specific needs, such as entertainment, information, or social interaction. The internet has led to an explosion of media options, allowing people to find content that caters to their needs and preferences more easily.

Likewise, the *Cultivation Theory* highlights exposure to media over time can shape a person's perception of reality. While traditional media, such as television, was the primary focus of this theory, the internet has become a major source of news and information for many people, leading to questions about how exposure to digital media might shape our understanding of the world.

Lastly, the *Social Learning Theory* posits that people learn new behaviours and attitudes by observing and imitating the behaviours of others. With the rise of social media, people are more connected than ever before, and social learning can occur online through exposure to the opinions and behaviours of others on platforms like Twitter, Facebook, and Instagram.

Therefore, on the one hand, the digital revolution has led to the development of new media theories. On the other hand, some traditional theories have adapted and evolved to reflect the changing media landscape.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1. How has technology transformed our everyday lives and environment?

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2. Discuss the transition of traditional media theories due to the advent of the internet.

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12.4 THEORIES I: SOCIOLOGICAL PERSPECTIVE

The digital revolution has significantly impacted media sociological theories, fundamentally changing how people interact with media and each other. New media technologies have enabled people to create, share, and consume media content on a personal level rather than just consuming media from a few sources. This has led to the development of new theories of communication that focus on individual and social interaction rather than mass communication. Similarly, the internet has also impacted social structures, such as how people form communities and interact with each other. This has

led to the development of new theories of social media and online communities, such as network theory and the theory of online identity.

We will discuss some significant theories on digital media in the next section.

12.4.1 Media Convergence

Media Convergence refers to merging previously distinct media technologies, platforms, and content into a single, integrated system. In other words, media convergence is the process by which various forms of media, such as television, radio, newspapers, books, music, and video games, are brought together into a single digital platform.

Media convergence is made possible by digital technologies, which allow for integrating different types of media content onto a single device or platform, such as a smartphone, tablet, or computer. For example, a single device can now be used to watch television shows, stream music, read news articles, and play video games on the same screen.

Media convergence has significant implications for media companies, consumers, and society as a whole. For media companies, convergence means adapting to new technologies and finding new ways to monetise their content. Convergence means increased convenience and access to a wider variety of consumer media content. According to Jenkins (2006), convergence represents a cultural shift in which consumers actively produce content, seek new information, and make connections between disparate media content. They do so by using varied media platforms. In these terms, the active production and consumption of media content creatively alters the logic by which media audiences operate, thus changing how media industries operate.

However, it also raises questions about privacy, intellectual property, and the quality and reliability of the information.

Media convergence has transformed how we consume, create, and engage with media content, and it will likely continue to shape our lives in significant ways.

12.4.2 The Internet and the Public Sphere

The concept of the public sphere, which German philosopher Jürgen Habermas first introduced in the 1960s, refers to the space where citizens can come together to engage in rational and informed debate about issues of public concern. This space is characterised by openness, inclusivity, and democratic deliberation and is essential for the functioning of a healthy democracy.

The internet has profoundly impacted the concept of the public sphere. On the one hand, the internet has expanded the potential reach and inclusivity of the public sphere. With the rise of social media platforms and online forums, people worldwide can now come together to share information, debate issues, and engage in political discourse.

However, the internet has also raised concerns about the fragmentation and

polarisation of the public sphere. With the proliferation of online echo chambers and filter bubbles, people are increasingly consuming information and engaging in discourse with like-minded individuals rather than engaging with diverse perspectives and engaging in democratic deliberation.

Furthermore, the internet has also raised questions about the quality and reliability of the information in the public sphere. With the rise of fake news and disinformation campaigns, it is increasingly difficult for citizens to engage in informed and rational debate about issues of public concern.

Therefore, the relationship between the Internet and the concept of the public sphere is complex and multifaceted. While the Internet can potentially expand the reach and inclusivity of the public sphere, it also poses significant challenges to its openness, inclusivity, and democratic deliberation.

12.4.3 Remediation

Remediation theory was introduced by media theorists Jay David Bolter and Richard Grusin in their book "Remediation: Understanding New Media" in 1999. The theory suggests that media technologies are constantly remediating or borrowing from one another as new forms of media are created and adapted to meet changing cultural and social needs.

According to the Remediation theory, all media are influenced by earlier forms of media, and new media are often created by combining or remediating earlier forms of media. For example, television news borrows from print journalism, while online news borrows from both print and television journalism.

The theory also suggests that new media technologies are often created in response to perceived shortcomings in existing media. As a result, new media often remediate earlier forms of media by incorporating or improving upon their features. For example, digital photography remediates traditional photography by allowing for instant image capture, editing, and sharing.

Remediation theory has significant implications for media production and consumption. It suggests that media technologies are constantly evolving and changing and that producers and consumers must constantly adapt to these changes to remain relevant. It also suggests that media audiences are active participants in the process of media production, as they influence the development and evolution of new media technologies through their consumption and feedback.

12.4.4 Information Society

The concept of an information society refers to a society where information and knowledge play a central role in the economy, social structure, and cultural life. Information and knowledge are considered valuable commodities and key drivers of economic growth and innovation in an information society.

The term "information society" was first coined in the 1960s and 1970s by sociologists and economists interested in how technological advancements in

computing and communications transformed society. With the rise of digital technologies and the internet, the idea of an information society has become increasingly relevant and has been the subject of much research and debate.

Individuals and organisations increasingly depend on access to information and communication technologies (ICTs) to perform their daily activities in an information society. This includes activities such as work, education, socialising, and entertainment. As a result, the availability and quality of ICT infrastructure, such as broadband internet access, are important factors in determining a community or country's social and economic well-being.

Critics of the concept of an information society argue that it tends to over-emphasise the role of technology and downplay the importance of social, political, and economic factors in shaping society. Additionally, there are concerns that the widespread use of ICTs may lead to increased social isolation, privacy violations, and other negative societal effects.

12.4.5 Networked Publics

The concept of "networked publics" was introduced by Danah Boyd, a scholar and researcher in the field of digital media and technology. In her book "It's Complicated: The Social Lives of Networked Teens" and various academic papers, Boyd explores how digital networks and social media have transformed the nature of public and social interaction, particularly among young people. She argues that networked publics have both positive and negative effects on social life and that understanding these effects is crucial for addressing contemporary social and political issues.

The concept of "networked publics" refers to the online communities and social spaces that have emerged through the use of digital networks and social media platforms. These networked publics are characterised by their ability to connect people across geographic and cultural boundaries, enabling new forms of communication, collaboration, and collective action.

Networked publics are different from traditional publics in several ways. First, they are often more diverse and inclusive, as people from different backgrounds and cultures can come together in these spaces. Second, they are often more participatory and interactive, as users can actively engage with one another through various online tools and platforms. Third, they are often more decentralised and fluid, as users can form and dissolve communities quickly and easily.

One of the key features of networked publics is their ability to enable new forms of collective action and political engagement. For example, social media platforms have been used to organise protests, rallies, and other forms of political activism. They have also been used to raise awareness about social and political issues and to mobilise support for social and political causes.

However, networked publics are not without their challenges and drawbacks. They can also be used to spread misinformation, harass and bully others, and reinforce existing social and political divisions. As a result, there is an ongoing debate about the role of the networked public in shaping public

discourse and promoting democratic values.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1. What is media convergence?

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2. What do you understand by the Remediation theory?

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3. Discuss the concept of networked publics.

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12.5 THEORIES II: TECHNOLOGICAL PERSPECTIVE

The rise of digital media and the internet has led to significant transformations in media theories as scholars seek to understand how technology shapes media production, consumption, and distribution. These theories include the network society theory, which emphasises the importance of digital networks in shaping contemporary society, and the platform theory, which focuses on the role of platforms like social media and search engines in shaping media content and audiences.

Furthermore, technology has also impacted existing media theories by providing new insights and perspectives. For example, technological advancements have allowed researchers to conduct more extensive and accurate audience research, better understanding how audiences consume and interact with media content.

We will discuss some of such theories in the next section.

12.5.1 Network Society

The concept of a "network society" refers to a social and economic structure that is characterised by the widespread use of digital networks and communication technologies.

Manuel Castells first introduced the concept of network society in his book "The Rise of the Network Society", published in 1996. Castells is a prominent sociologist who has written extensively about the impact of digital networks and communication technologies on social and economic structures. In "The Rise of the Network Society," Castells argues that the widespread use of digital networks is transforming social and economic structures in powerful ways, creating new opportunities and challenges for individuals, organisations, and societies as a whole. The book is widely regarded as a seminal work in the field of media and communication studies and has had a significant impact on our understanding of the digital age.

According to Manuel Castells, a sociologist who has written extensively about the network society, this new form of social organisation is defined by several key features:

1. ***The centrality of information and communication technologies:*** In the network society, digital networks and communication technologies are central to social and economic life, shaping how people interact, work, and consume.
2. ***The rise of global networks:*** The network society is characterised by the emergence of global networks that connect people and organisations across geographic and cultural boundaries.
3. ***The decentralisation of power:*** In the network society, power is more decentralised than in traditional hierarchical structures. This is because digital networks enable people to communicate and collaborate without the need for centralised control.
4. ***The emergence of new forms of social organisation:*** The network society has enabled the emergence of new forms of social organisation, such as online communities, social networks, and virtual organisations.

Thus, the concept of the network society suggests that digital networks and communication technologies are fundamentally transforming social and economic structures, creating new opportunities and challenges for individuals, organisations, and societies as a whole.

12.5.2 Actor-Network Theory

The Actor-Network Theory (ANT) was developed by French sociologists Michel Callon, Bruno Latour, and John Law in the late 1980s and early 1990s. They were part of a broader sociology, science, and technology studies movement. They sought to challenge traditional notions of agency and social structure and rethink how we understand the relationships between humans, technologies, and other social actors. The theory posits that the relationships between actors (both human and non-human) and their networked interactions shape social behaviour and ultimately create social reality.

Since its introduction, the theory has been widely influential in various fields, including sociology, anthropology, and science and technology studies. It has provided a framework for understanding the complex relationships between actors and their networks in various social and technological contexts.

According to ANT, actors are not simply individuals but rather any entity or thing that is capable of acting, including technologies, institutions, and even ideas. These actors are seen as part of a larger network, and their actions and interactions shape the structure and dynamics of the network.

The ANT theory emphasises the importance of examining the relationships between actors and how they influence each other in complex ways. It argues that understanding social phenomena requires looking beyond individual actions and behaviours to examine the larger network of actors that shape and are shaped by social reality.

12.5.3 Technological Determinism

The concept of technological determinism has been discussed and debated by scholars across a range of fields, including sociology, philosophy, and media studies. However, the term "technological determinism" was first coined by the American economist and sociologist Thorstein Veblen in his 1921 book "The Engineers and the Price System". Veblen argued that the development of technology and the scientific method would inevitably lead to a "machine age" in which social and economic life would be dominated by technology and its influence. Since then, the concept has been developed and refined by numerous scholars, including Marshall McLuhan, Jacques Ellul, and Neil Postman.

Marshall McLuhan's Technological Determinism theory suggests technology is the primary driver of social and cultural change. According to McLuhan, the medium itself, rather than the content transmitted through it, profoundly impacts society and culture. McLuhan argued that each new medium, whether the printing press, the telegraph, or television, has distinct characteristics that shape how people perceive and interact with the world. For example, the printing press enabled the widespread dissemination of knowledge and the development of mass literacy. At the same time, television facilitated the development of a global village and a more visual and sensory form of communication.

McLuhan's theory of technological determinism also suggests that technology has the power to reshape society in ways that are not always predictable or controllable. He argued that people often adopt new technologies without fully understanding their implications and that these technologies can have unintended consequences.

While McLuhan's theory of technological determinism has been criticised for its deterministic view of technology and its impact on society, it remains an influential perspective on the relationship between technology and culture. Many scholars continue to explore how technology shapes society and the impact that emerging technologies, such as artificial intelligence and the Internet of Things (IoT), will have on our lives in the future.

12.5.4 The Technological Shaping of Everyday Life

Langdon Winner is often credited with introducing the concept of technological shaping of everyday life. In his influential book, "The Whale and the Reactor: A Search for Limits in an Age of High Technology,"

published in 1986, Winner argues that technology is not a neutral tool or instrument but rather shapes and influences our lives. Winner coined the term "technological somnambulism" to describe how we often unquestioningly accept new technologies without questioning their impact on society and the environment. Winner's work has been influential in the field of science and technology studies and has influenced the development of critical approaches to technology and society.

In line with the "social shaping of technology" school of thought, Raymond Williams stresses that the knowledge and acquired skills necessary to use a tool or machine are integral to any full concept of technology.

Williams differentiates between:

- Technical inventions and techniques upon which technology depends, the alphabet, appropriate tools or machines for making marks, and suitable surfaces for accurately retaining marks;
- The substantive technology, in terms of writing, is a distribution technology (it distributes language), and this requires a means or form—scrolls of papyrus, portable manuscripts, mass-produced printed books, letters, or emails, and other kinds of electronic text;
- The technology in social use. This includes (a) the specialised practice of writing, which was initially restricted to minorities and then opened up, through education, to larger sections of society, and (b) the social part of the distribution of the technologically reproduced language, which again was only extended in response to perceived social needs.

The concept of technological shaping of everyday life suggests that technology plays a significant role in our daily lives. From the moment we wake up until we go to bed at night, we are surrounded by technology and constantly interacting with it.

12.5.5 Cyborg Manifesto and Critical Posthumanism

The Cyborg Manifesto is a feminist essay written by Donna Haraway in 1984. The essay explores the cyborg concept as a metaphor for challenging and rethinking traditional ideas of identity, gender, and power in a world increasingly shaped by technology and science.

In the essay, Haraway argues that the traditional categories of "nature" and "culture" are no longer useful for understanding the complex relationships between humans and technology and that the cyborg can be seen as a hybrid entity that blurs the boundaries between humans and machine, biology and technology, and physical and virtual reality. According to Haraway, the cyborg can be seen as a figure that challenges and subverts traditional categories of identity and power and offers new possibilities for imagining and enacting resistance and social change. In this sense, the cyborg represents a kind of "political myth" that can inspire new ways of thinking and acting in the world.

The Cyborg Manifesto and the concept of critical posthumanism are closely related, as they both seek to challenge traditional ideas of human identity and

subjectivity and explore the complex relationships between humans and technology. On the one hand, critical posthumanism is a theoretical approach that emphasises the need to rethink traditional concepts of the human and the non-human and recognise how technology and other non-human entities shape our identities and social relationships. The approach draws on various fields, including philosophy, cultural studies, and science and technology studies, to explore the implications of these changes for ethics, politics, and social justice. On the other hand, the Cyborg Manifesto is often seen as a key text in the development of critical posthumanism, as it offers a provocative and innovative approach to thinking about the relationship between humans and technology. The essay challenges traditional ideas of identity, gender, and power and suggests that the cyborg can be seen as a figure that embodies the potential for resistance and transformation.

Both the Cyborg Manifesto and critical posthumanism emphasise the need to recognise and engage with how technology and other non-human entities shape our lives and to develop new ways of thinking and acting that are responsive to these changes. In this sense, they offer a critique of traditional humanism and a call to rethink our assumptions about what it means to be human in a world increasingly shaped by technology.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1. What are the key features of network society?

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2. What do you understand by technological determinism?

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3. How are the cyborg manifesto and critical posthumanism related?

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12.6 LET US SUM UP

This unit has reflected upon various frameworks and theories in the context of digital media that seek to explain how digital technologies and media are

changing how we communicate, think, and interact with each other and the world around us. These theories draw on various disciplines, including communication studies, sociology, anthropology, psychology, and philosophy.

These theories have sought to explore questions such as how digital media technologies are changing our social, cultural, and economic practices, how they are transforming the way we communicate, how they are shaping our identities and communities, and the role of technology amidst this transformation. The sociological and technological perspective demonstrated key themes of convergence, networked communication, the socio-cultural implications of technology, and vice versa. Some notable digital media theorists include Henry Jenkins, Manuel Castells, Donna Haraway, Lev Manovich, and Sherry Turkle.

12.7 KEYWORDS

Media Convergence: The merging of previously separate forms of media, such as television, radio, print, and the internet, into a single, integrated medium.

Remediation Theory: The idea that all media are constantly reworking and repurposing elements of previous media, creating a constant cycle of borrowing and adaptation.

Networked Publics: A term coined by Danah Boyd to describe online communities and social networks and how they are shaped by technology, culture and social norms.

Network Society: A term coined by Manuel Castells to describe a society in which communication networks and digital technologies are central to social and economic life.

Technological Determinism: The idea that technology is the driving force behind social and cultural change and that it has the power to shape and transform society.

Actor-Network Theory: A theoretical framework that views social and technological entities as interconnected and emphasises the role of both humans and non-humans in shaping social and cultural systems.

Cyborg Manifesto: A feminist essay by Donna Haraway that uses the cyborg figure as a metaphor for challenging traditional ideas of identity, gender, and power.

Critical Posthumanism: A theoretical approach that challenges traditional ideas of human identity and subjectivity and recognises how technology and other non-human entities shape our lives.

12.8 FURTHER READINGS

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12.9 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

1. Technology has transformed our everyday lives in the following ways:
 - Computer-mediated communications: email, chat rooms, avatar-based communication forums, voice image transmissions, the World Wide Web, blogs, etc., social networking sites, and mobile telephony.
 - New ways of distributing and consuming media texts are characterised by interactivity and hypertextual formats- the World Wide Web, CD, DVD, Podcasts, and the various platforms for computer games.
 - Virtual ‘realities’: simulated environments and immersive representational spaces
 - A whole range of transformations and dislocations of established media (in, for example, photography, animation, television, journalism, film, and cinema).
2. The transition of traditional media theories due to the advent of the internet:
 - **Agenda Setting Theory:** Research has shown that social media platforms such as Twitter can still influence the public agenda by amplifying certain issues and creating a sense of urgency around them.
 - **Uses and Gratification Theory:** The internet has led to an explosion of media options, allowing people to more easily find content that caters to their individual needs and preferences.
 - **Cultivation Theory:** While traditional media such as television was the primary focus of this theory, the internet has become a major source of news and information for many people, leading to questions about how exposure to digital media might shape our understanding of the world.
 - **Social Learning Theory:** With the rise of social media, people are more connected than ever before, and social learning can occur online through exposure to the opinions and behaviours of others on platforms like Twitter, Facebook, and Instagram.

Check Your Progress 2

1. **Media Convergence:** The merging of previously separate forms of media, such as television, radio, print, and the internet, into a single, integrated medium.
2. **Remediation Theory:** The idea that all media are constantly reworking and repurposing elements of previous media, creating a constant cycle of borrowing and adaptation.
3. **Networked Publics:** A term coined by Danah Boyd to describe online communities and social networks and how they are shaped by technology, culture, and social norms.

Check Your Progress 3

1. Key features of the network society:
 - The centrality of information and communication technologies
 - The rise of global networks
 - The decentralisation of power
 - The emergence of new forms of social organisation
2. Marshall McLuhan's Technological Determinism theory suggests technology is the primary driver of social and cultural change. According to McLuhan, the medium itself, rather than the content transmitted through it, profoundly impacts society and culture.
3. Both the Cyborg Manifesto and critical posthumanism emphasise the need to recognise and engage with how technology and other non-human entities shape our lives and to develop new ways of thinking and acting that are responsive to these changes.

UNIT 13 PARTICIPATORY CULTURE

Structure

- 13.0 Introduction
- 13.1 Learning Outcomes
- 13.2 Approaches to Participation
- 13.3 Henry Jenkins' Participatory Culture
 - 13.3.1 Sub-Genres of Participation
 - 13.3.2 Forms of Participatory Culture
- 13.4 New Media Literacies' (NML) Framework
- 13.5 Applicability of Participatory Culture
 - 13.5.1 In Real Life
 - 13.5.2 On Social Media
- 13.6 Let Us Sum Up
- 13.7 Keywords
- 13.8 Further Readings
- 13.9 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

13.0 INTRODUCTION

Digital media has played a crucial role in facilitating participation and engagement online. Through the widespread use of digital technologies, individuals can now create, share, and access media content in new and innovative ways, allowing them to connect with others and participate in various online communities. The internet has also made it easier for individuals to access information and share their own perspectives, providing a platform for greater democratic participation and civic engagement. Social media platforms like Facebook, Twitter, and Instagram have created new spaces for dialogue and conversation, allowing individuals to connect with others who share their interests, values, and beliefs.

Moreover, digital media has opened up new opportunities for creative expression and collaboration, as individuals can now easily create and share their own media content, from blog posts and podcasts to videos and online games. This has led to the development of new forms of participatory culture, where individuals are actively involved in creating and disseminating media content rather than just consuming it.

The concept of participatory culture emerged as a response to the rapid changes that have taken place in media and technology over the past few decades. In the 1990s, the rise of digital technologies, such as the internet, personal computers, and mobile phones, fundamentally changed how people interacted with media and each other. As a result of these changes, a growing number of scholars and activists began to argue that traditional models of media consumption were no longer adequate for understanding the role of media in society. Instead, they called for a new model that recognised the

active and participatory role that individuals were now playing in creating and sharing media content.

In this Unit, we shall discuss in detail the participatory culture, the social skills and cultural competencies that individuals can partake in, and its applicability.

13.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After reading this Unit, you will be able to:

- describe the approaches to participation;
- explain participatory culture from the media literacy perspective;
- discuss the social skills and cultural competencies; and
- apply participatory culture in real life and on social media.

13.2 APPROACHES TO PARTICIPATION

There are several approaches to online participation, including:

- **Active participation:** This approach involves actively engaging with others online, whether through comments on social media posts, participating in online forums or discussion groups, or creating and sharing one's own media content.
- **Passive participation:** This approach involves consuming media content online without actively engaging with others or contributing to the conversation. This may include watching videos, reading articles, or browsing social media without commenting or sharing content.
- **Lurking** involves observing or reading online content without actively participating or contributing to the conversation. While this approach may not involve active engagement, it can still be a valuable form of online participation as it allows individuals to learn and gather information.
- **Collaborative participation:** This approach involves actively collaborating online to create and share media content. This may include working on group projects, contributing to open-source software development, or participating in crowdsourcing initiatives.
- **Critical participation:** This approach involves engaging with media content online critically and reflectively. This may involve questioning the validity of information, examining biases or assumptions, or analysing media content's social, cultural, or political implications.

These approaches to online participation are not mutually exclusive, and individuals may engage in multiple forms of participation depending on their interests and goals. By understanding these approaches, individuals can develop a more nuanced and informed approach to online participation that allows them to engage in meaningful and impactful ways.

Therefore, online participatory media enables more people in different countries to communicate with each other more easily and directly than ever before, without depending on governments or professional media to enable and mediate this conversation. Such cross-border conversations can be channelised to bridge significant cultural and digital divides. The newness of online participatory media is its ability to perform the following functions:

- ***Fostering community and social connections:*** Online participatory media provides individuals with new ways to connect with others who share similar interests and values and can help foster a sense of community and belonging. Participatory media platforms such as social media networks, forums, and online games allow individuals to interact with each other in real-time, share information and resources, and collaborate on projects and initiatives.
- ***Facilitating learning and skill development:*** Online participatory media allows individuals to learn new skills and knowledge and develop their existing skills and knowledge in new and innovative ways. Participatory media platforms such as online tutorials, wikis, and MOOCs (massive open online courses) allow individuals to access a wealth of educational resources and to engage in self-directed learning.
- ***Enabling creative expression and innovation:*** Online participatory media provides individuals with new ways to express themselves creatively and to share their ideas and perspectives with a wider audience. Participatory media platforms such as blogs, podcasts, and video-sharing sites allow individuals to create and share their own media content and collaborate with others to produce new and innovative forms of media.
- ***Promoting civic engagement and activism:*** Online participatory media provides individuals with new ways to engage in civic and political activism and to mobilise others around social and political issues. Participatory media platforms such as online petitions, social media campaigns, and citizen journalism sites allow individuals to voice their opinions and concerns and to participate in public discourse in new and innovative ways.
- ***Promoting economic and entrepreneurial opportunities:*** Online participatory media provides individuals with new opportunities to participate in the economy and to develop their own businesses and entrepreneurial ventures. Participatory media platforms such as online marketplaces, crowdfunding sites, and e-commerce platforms allow individuals to sell goods and services, raise funds for projects, and develop their own online businesses.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1. What are the approaches to participation?

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2. Discuss the functions of online participatory media.

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13.3 HENRY JENKINS' PARTICIPATORY CULTURE

Henry Jenkins, a media scholar and professor at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT), was one of the leading figures in developing the concept of participatory culture. In his 2006 book, "Convergence Culture: Where Old and New Media Collide," Jenkins argued that participatory culture was emerging as a result of the convergence of traditional and new media forms and that it represented a major shift in the way that media was produced, distributed, and consumed.

Since then, the concept of participatory culture has become widely recognised and has been used to describe a range of social, cultural, and political phenomena, from fan fiction and remix culture to online activism and citizen journalism.

According to Jenkins et al. (2009), "participatory culture is emerging as the culture absorbs and responds to the explosion of new media technologies that make it possible for average consumers to archive, annotate, appropriate, and recirculate media content in powerful new ways."

Participatory culture is often used to discuss the apparent link between more accessible digital technologies, user-generated content, and some shift in the power relations between media industries and their consumers. The new media environment is in the process of creating a new model in which information flows both ways. An essential difference between traditional and interactive participatory media is how information flows. Interactive, participatory media transforms a one-way conversation between media and "audience" into a conversation with an "information community."

The notion of participatory culture, as per Jenkins et al. (2009), stems from three core gaps:

1. Participation Gap (unequal access to opportunities, experiences, skills and knowledge)
2. Transparency Problem (difficulty to recognise how media shapes their perception)
3. Ethics Challenge (ethics to communicate and participate responsibly in online media spaces)

Therefore, the role of media education and literacy becomes imperative to make online media a dynamic environment to be engaged with up to its full

potential. Moreover, the participatory culture shifts the focus on literacy from individual expression to community involvement, especially among young people.

13.3.1 Sub-Genres of Participation

Jenkins et al. (2009) initiated the idea of participatory culture amongst young people in the context of online media from a media literacy perspective. As per Jenkins et al. (2009), young people play the role of consumers and producers in online media spaces. Ito et al. (2009) illustrate that youth participate in online media spaces for two primary purposes- driven and interest-driven.

In this context, Ito et al. (2009) identify three sub-genres of participation: hanging out (friendship-driven participation), messing around (acquiring a new skill online) and geeking out (intensive and focused participation after acquiring the skill online; hence, learning).

These sub-genres are:

1. **"Hanging Out"**: This sub-genre of participation refers to the social and recreational activities that individuals engage in online, such as chatting with friends, sharing media content, and participating in online communities. Hanging out online allows individuals to connect with others who share similar interests and to develop social networks and relationships.
2. **"Messing Around"**: This sub-genre of participation refers to the playful and exploratory activities that individuals engage in online, such as tinkering with digital media tools and experimenting with different forms of creative expression. Messing online allows individuals to develop their skills and knowledge in a fun and low-stakes environment and learn through trial and error.
3. **"Geeking Out"**: This sub-genre of participation refers to the more focused and intensive activities that individuals engage in online, such as pursuing a particular interest or passion, collaborating on a project, or developing expertise in a particular area. Geeking out online allows individuals to develop their skills and knowledge in a more formal and structured way and to participate in online communities and networks of practice.

13.3.2 Forms of Participatory Culture

There are four forms of participatory culture:

1. **Affiliations**: This refers to how individuals use online participatory media to connect with others who share similar interests, goals, and values. The development of social networks, online communities, and other forms of collective identity characterises affiliations.
2. **Expressions**: This refers to how individuals use online participatory media to express themselves creatively through the creation and sharing of media content such as blogs, videos, podcasts, and digital art.
3. **Collaborative Problem-Solving**: This refers to how individuals use online participatory media to solve problems or create new knowledge

through crowdsourcing, collective intelligence, and peer production.

4. **Circulations:** This refers to how individuals use online participatory media to share and distribute media content, ideas, and information with others through activities such as blogging, microblogging, social networking, and other forms of digital communication. Circulations involve the creation of new forms of media and the dissemination of content across a range of different platforms and channels.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1. What is participatory culture?

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2. What are the four forms of participatory culture?

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13.4 NEW MEDIA LITERACIES' (NML) FRAMEWORK

Jenkins et al. (2009) have identified 11 new media literacies comprehensively covering social skills and cultural competencies amongst young people to participate in online media spaces fully. The new media literacies' framework is based on traditional literacy, research skills, technical skills, and critical analysis skills taught in the classroom and is developed through collaborations and networking. Therefore, participatory culture combines traditional literacy skills (how to search for information, evaluate the credibility of information, synthesise and make sense of information, and make a decision and action) and new media literacy (social skills or methods of interaction with larger communities).

The core media literacy skills are as follows:

1. **Play: the capacity to experiment with one's surroundings as a form of problem-solving**

This skill involves a willingness to take risks, try new things, and learn through trial and error. In a participatory culture, play can take many different forms, such as experimenting with different digital tools and technologies, exploring new genres of media content, or developing creative solutions to complex problems. Through play, individuals can

develop their creativity, problem-solving abilities, and sense of agency as they learn to navigate and shape their environments in new and innovative ways.

One example of play in Jenkins' participatory culture is the phenomenon of fan fiction. Fan fiction is when fans of a particular TV show, movie, book, or video game create their own stories and characters based on the original source material. Fan fiction is a form of play because it allows individuals to engage with their favourite media playfully and creatively. Fans can exercise their imagination and develop their storytelling skills by writing their own stories and exploring new narratives and characters. In addition to fan fiction, other examples of play in participatory culture include online games, memes, and other forms of creative expression that allow individuals to experiment, tinker, and explore in a playful and low-stakes environment.

2. Simulation: the ability to interpret and construct dynamic models of real-world processes

In other words, simulation involves creating virtual representations of real-world phenomena, such as simulations of weather patterns, economic systems, or social interactions. Simulation is an important skill in participatory culture because it allows individuals to experiment with complex systems and explore the consequences of different actions and decisions. For example, simulations of historical events or political processes can help individuals better understand how these systems work and how they might be improved. Similarly, simulations of scientific phenomena can help individuals learn about the natural world and develop scientific literacy.

In participatory culture, simulation often involves using digital tools and technologies, such as simulation software or virtual reality environments. However, simulation can also take other forms, such as role-playing games, model building, or other forms of imaginative play that allow individuals to simulate real-world processes and systems creatively and engagingly.

3. Performance: the ability to adopt alternative identities for improvisation and discovery

Performance involves taking on different roles and engaging in different forms of self-presentation. For example, individuals might adopt different personas or avatars in online gaming communities or social media platforms or create and share videos or other media content that showcase their creative talents.

Performance is an important skill in participatory culture because it allows individuals to explore different aspects of their identity and experiment with varying forms of self-expression. Individuals can develop their empathy, creativity, and understanding of different perspectives and experiences by taking on alternative identities or exploring different social contexts.

In participatory culture, performance often involves using digital tools

and technologies, such as video editing software or social media platforms. However, performance can also take other forms, such as theatre, music, or other forms of creative expression, that allow individuals to engage in different forms of self-presentation and explore different aspects of their identity.

4. Appropriation: the ability to meaningfully sample and remix media content

It refers to the ability to meaningfully remix, reuse, or repurpose existing media content and cultural artefacts to create something new. Appropriation involves taking existing cultural artefacts, such as music, images, or video, and creatively reworking them to produce something new and original. For example, individuals might create mashup videos that combine footage from different movies or TV shows to create a new narrative or meaning, or they might remix songs to create a new musical composition.

Appropriation is important in participatory culture because it allows individuals to engage with and contribute to the broader cultural landscape. By remixing and repurposing existing content, individuals can add their own unique perspectives and interpretations to the cultural discourse while also building upon the work of others.

In participatory culture, appropriation often involves using digital tools and technologies, such as editing software or online sharing platforms. However, appropriation can also take other forms, such as collage, graffiti, or other forms of creative expression that involve remixing and repurposing existing materials.

5. Multitasking: the ability to scan one's environment and shift focus onto salient details on an ad hoc basis

Multitasking involves the ability to manage and process multiple forms of information and media content, such as text messages, social media notifications, video streams, and audio content, all at the same time. This skill requires individuals to switch rapidly between different forms of content and effectively manage their attention and focus.

Multitasking is an important skill in participatory culture because it allows individuals to effectively engage with and participate in the vast array of online media content and information. By mastering the skill of multitasking, individuals can stay up-to-date on current events, communicate with others, and consume a wide range of media content, all while maintaining a high level of productivity.

In participatory culture, multitasking often involves using digital tools and technologies, such as multiple screens, mobile devices, and software applications, that enable individuals to efficiently navigate and process multiple streams of information and media content.

6. Distributed Cognition: The ability to interact meaningfully with tools that expand our mental capacities.

It refers to the ability to share and distribute cognitive tasks across individuals and technologies to achieve a common goal. Distributed

cognition involves using technology and social networks to distribute and share cognitive tasks and resources across individuals and groups. For example, individuals might collaborate on a shared document or project using online tools such as Google Docs or participate in online communities or social networks to share ideas and knowledge with others.

Distributed cognition is an important skill in participatory culture because it enables individuals to tap into the collective intelligence and knowledge of a larger network or community. By sharing cognitive tasks and resources, individuals can achieve more complex and ambitious goals than they could accomplish alone.

In participatory culture, distributed cognition often involves using digital tools and technologies, such as collaborative platforms, social media networks, and online communities. However, distributed cognition can also take other forms, such as face-to-face collaborations and group projects that rely on shared cognitive resources and knowledge.

7. **Collective Intelligence:** the ability to pool knowledge and compare notes with others towards a common goal

Collective intelligence involves using technology and social networks to harness the collective knowledge and expertise of a larger group or community. For example, individuals might collaborate on a shared document or project using online tools such as Google Docs or participate in online communities or social networks to share ideas and knowledge with others.

Collective intelligence is important in participatory culture because it enables individuals to tap into a larger network or community's diverse perspectives, skills, and knowledge. By pooling resources and knowledge, individuals can solve more complex and difficult problems than they can on their own.

In participatory culture, collective intelligence often involves using digital tools and technologies, such as collaborative platforms, social media networks, and online communities. However, collective intelligence can also take other forms, such as face-to-face collaborations and group projects that rely on shared knowledge and expertise.

8. **Judgment: the ability to evaluate the reliability and credibility of different information sources**

It refers to the ability to evaluate and critically assess the quality, accuracy, and credibility of information and media content. Judgment involves using critical thinking skills to assess the reliability and validity of information and media content. This includes evaluating sources, assessing bias, and fact-checking information before accepting it as true. Individuals with strong judgment skills can distinguish between reliable and unreliable sources of information. They can assess the accuracy and credibility of media content before sharing it with others.

Judgment is an important skill in participatory culture because of the vast amount of information and media content that is available online. With

so much information and media content being produced and shared daily, individuals must be able to critically assess and evaluate the quality and accuracy of this content to avoid spreading misinformation or false information.

In participatory culture, judgment often involves using digital tools and technologies, such as fact-checking websites and online research tools. However, the judgment also relies on strong critical thinking skills and a healthy dose of scepticism to ensure that individuals can make informed decisions and evaluate information and media content responsibly and effectively.

9. Transmedia Navigation: the ability to deal with the flow of stories and information across multiple modalities

Transmedia navigation involves moving fluidly across different media platforms, such as social media networks, video-sharing sites, and online communities, and understanding how information is presented and consumed across these different platforms. This includes following and understanding multiplatform storytelling, identifying and navigating different distribution channels, and interpreting and evaluating information across different media formats.

Transmedia navigation is an important skill in participatory culture because of the vast amount of information and media content that is available across different platforms and formats. With so many different media sources and channels available, it is critical that individuals can navigate and make sense of this information coherently and effectively.

In participatory culture, transmedia navigation often involves using digital tools and technologies, such as social media monitoring tools and content aggregation platforms. However, transmedia navigation also relies on strong media literacy skills and an understanding of how media content is created, distributed, and consumed across different platforms and formats.

10. Networking: the ability to search for, synthesise, and disseminate information

It refers to the ability to build and maintain social connections and communities online. Networking involves connecting with others, building relationships, and collaborating with people across different geographical and cultural boundaries. This includes the ability to use social media platforms and online communities to establish and maintain connections and to communicate and collaborate with others on shared interests and goals.

Networking is an important skill in participatory culture because of the collaborative and social nature of many online communities and platforms. With the ability to connect with others online, individuals can participate in global conversations, share their ideas and perspectives, and work together to achieve common goals.

In participatory culture, networking often involves using digital tools and technologies, such as social media platforms and online communication

tools. However, networking also relies on strong interpersonal skills and building and maintaining meaningful relationships with others. By developing strong networking skills, individuals can build supportive and productive communities online and contribute to the growth and development of a participatory culture.

11. Negotiation: the ability to travel across diverse communities, discerning and respecting multiple perspectives, and grasping and following alternative sets of norms

Negotiation involves engaging in constructive dialogue, listening to other's perspectives, and working towards finding solutions that benefit all parties involved. This can involve negotiating differences in opinion or values and finding ways to reconcile conflicting interests.

Negotiation is an important skill in participatory culture because of the collaborative and cooperative nature of many online communities and platforms. With the ability to negotiate effectively, individuals can work together to achieve common goals, share resources and knowledge, and build sustainable and productive relationships.

In participatory culture, negotiation often involves using digital tools and technologies, such as online forums, chat rooms, and video conferencing. However, negotiation also relies on strong interpersonal skills and the ability to communicate effectively with others. By developing strong negotiation skills, individuals can contribute to the growth and development of participatory culture and work towards building more inclusive and equitable communities online.

Therefore, as highlighted by Jenkins et al. (2009), the core media literacy skills combine social skills and cultural competencies in and out of school for young people to adapt and learn virtually about the dynamic environment through the available tools. Apart from school, parents become another agency that can help shape young people's relationships with online tools for enhancing their mental capacities to be media and information-literate, from communication to effective participation in online media spaces.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1. Discuss the concept of play from the NML framework.

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2. What do you understand by Collective Intelligence?

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13.5 APPLICABILITY OF PARTICIPATORY CULTURE

13.5.1 In Real Life

Participatory culture has many practical applications in real life, both online and offline. Examples of some domains are:

1. **Civic engagement:** Participatory culture can be applied to civic engagement by encouraging individuals to actively participate in their communities and have a voice in the decisions that affect them. Through online platforms and tools, individuals can engage in public discussions, participate in online petitions, and collaborate with others to effect change in their communities.
2. **Education:** Participatory culture can be used to enhance learning by promoting active and collaborative learning. Teachers can encourage students to use digital tools and technologies to create and share their own media, engage in online discussions, and collaborate with their peers.
3. **Entertainment:** Participatory culture can be applied to entertainment by allowing individuals to engage with and contribute to their favourite media and cultural productions. Fans can participate in online forums, create fan art, and remix existing media to create their own content.
4. **Business:** Participatory culture can be applied to business by allowing customers to engage with brands and products, provide feedback, and collaborate on product development. Brands can leverage online communities and platforms to engage with customers, build loyalty, and develop new products and services.

Participatory culture can be applied in many different contexts and industries to promote collaboration, creativity, and community building. By encouraging individuals to participate in their communities actively and to have a voice in the decisions that affect them, participatory culture can help build more inclusive and equitable societies.

13.5.2 On Social Media

Participatory culture has significant applicability in social media, as social media platforms are built upon user participation and collaboration

principles. Here are some examples of how participatory culture can be applied in social media:

- ***User-generated content:*** Participatory culture in social media involves encouraging users to create and share their own content. Social media platforms such as YouTube, TikTok, and Instagram allow users to create and share videos, images, and other forms of media. By allowing users to create their own content, social media platforms promote creativity and collaboration and give users a sense of ownership and agency.
- ***Collaborative communities:*** Participatory culture in social media also involves the creation of collaborative communities where users can connect with others who share similar interests or goals. Social media platforms such as Facebook and Twitter allow users to join groups, follow hashtags, and engage in public discussions. By creating collaborative communities, social media platforms foster a sense of belonging and provide opportunities for users to collaborate and work together.
- ***User feedback:*** Participatory culture in social media also allows users to provide feedback on products, services, and content. Social media platforms like Yelp and TripAdvisor allow users to leave reviews and ratings for businesses and services. In contrast, YouTube and Instagram allow users to leave comments and feedback on videos and images. By providing a platform for user feedback, social media platforms promote transparency and accountability and give users a sense of agency and influence.
- ***Citizen journalism:*** Participatory culture in social media also involves citizen journalism, where users can report news and events in real time. Social media platforms such as Twitter and Instagram have been used to report on breaking news and events and have provided a platform for citizen journalists to share their perspectives and experiences. By allowing users to participate in news reporting, social media platforms promote citizen engagement and empower individuals to have a voice in the public sphere.

Therefore, participatory culture has significant applicability in social media and can promote collaboration, creativity, and community building in online spaces. By encouraging users to participate and engage with one another, social media platforms can help build more inclusive and equitable societies.

13.6 LET US SUM UP

We have learned in this Unit that the scope for new media to be more participatory arose from its apparent structural differences from the forms of mass communication that had been predominant media models in 20th-century societies. The rise of interactive media platforms has made it possible for untrained news professionals to be more directly engaged with news events than ever before.

We also learned that online space is both a space of participation on the one hand and a space for commodification. Lastly, participatory culture can promote empowerment, collaboration, diversity, learning, and civic engagement. By encouraging individuals to participate in creating and disseminating content actively, participatory culture can help build more inclusive, equitable, and democratic societies.

13.7 KEYWORDS

Participatory Culture: Participatory culture is emerging as the culture absorbs and responds to the explosion of new media technologies that make it possible for average consumers to archive, annotate, appropriate, and recirculate media content in powerful new ways

New Media Literacies' (NML) Framework: The new media literacies' framework is based on traditional literacy, research skills, technical skills, and critical analysis skills taught in the classroom and is developed through collaborations and networking.

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13.9 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

1. The approaches to participation are:
 - Active participation
 - Passive participation
 - Lurking
 - Collaborative participation
 - Critical participation
2. Functions of online participatory media:
 - Fostering community and social connections
 - Facilitating learning and skill development
 - Enabling creative expression and innovation
 - Promoting civic engagement and activism
 - Promoting economic and entrepreneurial opportunities

Check Your Progress 2

1. According to Jenkins et al. (2009), “participatory culture is emerging as the culture absorbs and responds to the explosion of new media technologies that make it possible for average consumers to archive, annotate, appropriate, and recirculate media content in powerful new ways.”
2. There are four forms of participatory culture:
 - **Affiliations** – forming formal and informal memberships in online communities centred around various forms of online media such as Friendster, Facebook, message boards, metagaming, game clans, etc.
 - **Expressions** – producing new forms such as digital sampling, skinning and modding, fan videomaking, fan fiction writing, zines, mash-ups, etc.
 - **Collaborative Problem-Solving** – working in formal and informal teams to complete tasks and develop new knowledge through Wikipedia, alternative reality gaming, spoiling, etc.
 - **Circulations** – shaping the flow of media through podcasting and blogging.

Check Your Progress 3

1. Play as a skill involves a willingness to take risks, try new things, and learn through trial and error. In a participatory culture, play can take many forms, such as experimenting with different digital tools and technologies, exploring new genres of media content, or developing creative solutions to complex problems. Through play, individuals can

develop their creativity, problem-solving abilities, and sense of agency as they learn to navigate and shape their environments in new and innovative ways.

2. Collective intelligence involves using technology and social networks to harness the collective knowledge and expertise of a larger group or community. For example, individuals might collaborate on a shared document or project using online tools such as Google Docs or participate in online communities or social networks to share ideas and knowledge with others.



UNIT 14 SOCIAL MOVEMENTS AND DIGITAL MEDIA

Structure

- 14.0 Introduction
- 14.1 Learning Outcome
- 14.2 Understanding Social Movement
 - 14.2.1 Characteristics of Social Movement
 - 14.2.2 Classification of Social Movement
- 14.3 Understanding Digital Media
 - 14.3.1 Social Influence of Digital Media
 - 14.3.2 Public Opinion Formation Through Digital Media
 - 14.3.3 Web2.0 Tools Make a Difference
- 14.4 Types of Digital Media Activism
 - 14.4.1 Channels of Communication in Digital Activism
 - 14.4.2 Digital Activism as Connective Action
- 14.5 Social Movement through Digital Media: Global Trends
 - 14.5.1 Hashtag Activism
 - 14.5.2 Digital Media Activism: Indian Experiences
- 14.6 Let Us Sum Up
- 14.7 Further Reading
- 14.8 Check Your Progress

14.0 INTRODUCTION

Wanting any change in the social system can call for the requisite action taken by citizens. Social movements are the social actions taken by the country's citizens, which are of various kinds, resorted at different levels to transform societies. The advent of Digital communication technologies and their proliferation has further shaped new prospects for activists to connect and organise themselves.

The predominant use of digital media technologies, e.g., the Internet, social media applications, and mobile communications, have transformed how citizens address and resolve socio-political issues, altering the nature of the social movement. The Internet has made it easier for an individual citizen and quicker to pursue a cause, discuss, and dispense news, facts, and stories worldwide concerning a wide variety of issues.

At the very outset, the unit begins with understanding social movement, its characteristics, and the classification of social movement. Then, the unit discusses the concept of digital media, web 2.0, its role in digital activism, and how digital media influences social action. The unit further discusses the various types of digital media activism and how digital media activism differs from the old-style social movement. The unit will provide the learner

exposure to the conceptual understanding of social movement and activism and the use of digital media in social activism with references to global trends and Indian experiences.

14.1 LEARNING OUTCOME

After reading this unit, the learners will be able to:

- comprehend the conceptual understanding of social movement and activism;
- identify the characteristics and classification of social movement;
- comprehend the concept of digital media activism and how activism through digital media differs from old-style social movement;
- understand the types of digital media activism;
- identify the channels of communication in digital media activism; and
- learn the global trends and Indian experiences related to social movement through digital media.

14.2 UNDERSTANDING SOCIAL MOVEMENT

The social movement is social action for social, political, economic, or environmental change, an action undertaken collectively to lessen or resolve a social problem. The term social movement falls in the discipline of political sociology and takes into account different terminologies such as collective action, networks, democracy, power, and resistance.

The collective effort is used to be sustained through either informal or formal mobilisation at an organisational setup to bring about change in the existing system of relationships. The pursuit of change is motivated towards either a helping cause or a revolutionary cause aiming to benefit mostly marginalised sections of society. The social movement encompasses conscious, systematic, and organised efforts to bring social change. The social movement covers various issues ranging from social, environmental, and human rights to local disputes.

Aiming to bring social change through protest and mass movement is not a new concept in India. India before and after independence witnessed a spell of socio-religious reform movements, including nationalist movements for India's independence and mass-based political movements for freedom struggle. Social reformists like Raja Rammohan Roy, Jyotiba Phule, Mahatma Gandhi, Shahu Maharaj, and Ambedkar fought against social evils in the nineteenth century. In the past, social movements concentrated on the issues concerning environmental degradation, the rights of the marginalised community, e.g., Dalits and tribals, women's questions, child labour, and so on.

Different strategies have been used in these social movements depending on socio-political situations, the goal and cause of the movement, and resources at the disposal of the activists. Some common strategies used in social movements are mass mobilisation, non-violent protests and persuasion,

legislative advocacy, media advocacy, public interest litigation, lobbying the bureaucrats, and so on.

Movements during the 19th and 20th centuries focused on the thematic contour of environmental protection, civil rights, women's rights, peace and anti-war, and rights of the LGBT (lesbian, gay, bisexual, and transgender) community have witnessed a change in terms used strategies in collective action with a teeming focus on overt practices such as meetings, petitioning, marches, rallies, and other non-violent resistance that eventually end up pressurising the policymakers and changing the legislation.

14.2.1 Characteristics of Social Movement

Studying social movements emphasises the formation of collective identities, political avenues, and mobilising structures. Accordingly, the key features of social movements include a collective attitude for mobilisation, change orientation, ideological framework, and fluid boundaries of membership. The elements such as collective goals, common ideology, collective action, and minimal organisation and leadership characterise any social movement.

Gerlach and Hine (1970) identified five key operationally significant characteristics in any social movement.

1. An organisation based on individual, structural-organisational, and socio-political ideological ties.
2. Uncompromising staffing of committed persons based on their pre-existing social bonding.
3. A committed leader with values and aspirations for bringing positive change in society.
4. An ideology that systematises the values and goals of the movement and delivers a conceptual framework by which practices or events connected to the goals may be understood. The ideology motivates and provides a rationale for the proposed action toward envisioned change. The ideology defines actors against whom to struggle and forms the basis for the intangible alliance of groups of people.
5. Real or perceived opposition from a society at large or from that segment of the established order within which the movement has arisen.

One crucial condition for collective action is a structural strain or social problem that causes people to be frustrated, leads to shared discontent, and creates a condition of shared grievances among some or most of the population to give rise to movement. James A. Davis (1959) and Ted Robert Gurr (1970) focus on relative deprivation when one group feels deprived of the other due to the iniquitous social condition that leads them to protest.

14.2.2 Classification of Social Movement

Sociologists distinguish several movements based on the nature and extent of the change they seek. M.S.A. R.A.O. (1979) classifies movement into three broad categories- 1) Reform, 2) Transformation and 3) Revolution.

The reform movement can be identified with the partial change in the values

and substantial change in the quality of relationships between people and the structure.

Transformational or transformative movements aim to bring about middle-level structural changes in the traditional distribution of power and the revolution identified with radical changes in the totality of social and cultural systems.

The revolutionary movement is often called a political movement as it seeks to overthrow the existing structure, e.g., the Russian and Chinese revolutions.

Reform movement triggers to improve the social condition within the existing regime, does not try to coup the prevailing structure seeks limited yet significant change in certain aspects of the political, economic, and social system of a nation, such as the civil war in the U.S.A., the contemporary women movement, the labour movement, the environment movement and so on.

The revolutionary movement employs a Marxist perspective to predict the cause, located in the economic structure of society or the conflicting interests between two antagonistic classes. The powerful class uses the repressive state power to control the powerless or have-not section of society. Have-not classes share a common interest and consciousness regarding their societal position and resist, protest, and revolt against the dominant class.

Activity 1

Take up a cause that triggers the take up of digital media and protest mobilisation across digital media platforms. Carry out an online survey and try to answer the following questions.

1. What is the cause of mobilisation?
2. What is the nature of the movement?
3. When and where did the mobilisation take place?
4. What are the strategies employed by the activists?
5. Write the role of digital media in propagation, resolution, or misrepresenting the cause.

14.3 UNDERSTANDING DIGITAL MEDIA

Digital media refers to content and information coded using technologies, which are modified and distributed on digital electronic devices and platforms.

Digital media encompasses all digital technologies such as the Internet, social media applications, and mobile phones and their associated ubiquitous web-based activities that include posting, sharing, commenting, and liking beyond reading a post or watching an online video.

Digital media offers a platform for different kinds of communication for creating and exchanging information, ideas, and opinions across virtual

networks and communities. The interactivity of digital media made access easier for individuals and communities who can share, deliberate upon any issues, make opinions, and co-produce and modify user-generated content.

The development of newer versions of digital media technology and its constant upgradation opens newer prospects for the horizontal flow of communication by accommodating conflicting numbers of voices without any influence of the vertical order. Social media in the form of social networking sites and mobile phones, another variant of digital media that appraises mainstream media about the status of social movements, meanwhile stimulates and influencing individual and groups and contribute to the continuity of the cause and goal of the movement during and after the occurrence of the movement.

14.3.1 Social Influence of Digital Media

The social influence of new technologies has evolved from an initial technophobic wave of opinion that did not believe in the democratic potential of the Internet, given the fences that separate the rich and poor countries from each other. It was not until 1992 that technophobia gradually began to dissolve with the cyberculture boom and the "dot.com" boom. Digital media technologies like mobile phones and mobile phone-enabled services become accessible to people and collectives with fewer financial resources. Access to digital media has further inspired and influenced activists to find and create new avenues for their cause. Digital media is conceived to form the 'third environment' as an ideological arena for activists and aid activists to form an alternative public sphere.

The philosopher Javier Echeverria mentions the rise of the 'third environment' (1999) that refers to electronic space made up of digital media technologies in opposition to the first two: nature and the city. The first environment predominates rural agricultural society, which mostly connects to nature. The second environment is city space representing the industrial society. Thus, the third environment talks of the information society and new technologies such as telephone, television, Internet, multimedia technologies such as CDRoms, DVDs, credit cards, and anything related to the information age.

The Internet plays a crucial role in the operation of contemporary social movements. In addition, the Internet has been proven to be an effective communication tool for intra and inter-group mobilisation.

Digital media, by enabling the mobilisation of individuals horizontally, has altered the organisational dynamics of social movement. Numerous examples from the Zapatistas, colour revolutions of Eastern Europe, Occupy Wall Street, the Arab Spring, and the Me Too movement have demonstrated the strength of digital media in informing, connecting, and mobilising the masses.

14.3.2 Public Opinion Formation Through Digital Media

From the 1990s onwards, activist groups mostly started using the Internet to accomplish their organisational goals. The Internet not only improves mobilisation efforts but also upturns the speed and reach of social

movements. Digital media's influence, reach, interactivity, and immediacy have complemented traditional mobilisation techniques yet obscured the same.

The year 1970 witnessed the emergence of Resource Mobilization theory as a significant paradigm for studying modern social movements (McCarthy & Zald 1977). It contends that the success of social movements depends on activists' use of political avenues and the effective mobilisation of various resources. Apart from the rational response to unsatisfactory conditions as a cause of discontent, what is crucial instead are efforts by social movement leaders to mobilise resources such as time, energy, and money of the populace and direct them into effective social action.

The resource mobilisation framework corroborates the uses of digital media and digital technologies and unleashes a new perspective on social movement literature. The utility social network can quickly foster communication, disseminate information and strengthen ties among activists while publicising social movements.

Connections developed in small networks of individuals, which may be extended to a larger scale, benefit more from digital media usage. Digital media has encouraged planning for social action, membership, and organisation, building consensus among the existing collectives and beyond. All these are possible through the avenues of participation provided by digital media.

Digital media helps form public opinion and bring new perspectives on any given issue or circumstance. Digital media facilitates many to many communications, forging a collective identity, shaping perception, forming public opinion, and translating it into action in the offline environment.

Advanced digital media provides a platform for interaction between people having similar views. Digital media has proven to be a powerful tool to influence public opinion and government policymaking. Digital tools and technologies not only reshape the forms of social movements but also familiarise us with newer types of resistance culture. With instant sharing features, digital platforms like social networking sites help people communicate, understand perception, and organise within social circles.

14.3.3 Web 2.0 Tools Make a Difference

The arrival of Web 2.0 has implicitly pitched up the trends of Web 1.0 that included emails, blogs, discussion forums, and chat messenger. The significant features distinguishing Web 2.0 from its predecessors include user-generated content, instantaneous feedback, self-sharing, quicker response, and scope for collaboration with a new participatory platform that aids alternative views and opinions of citizens.

The rise of activism on the Internet highlights the shift from past forms of activism that relied heavily on meetings and public demonstrations, e.g., sit-ins, meetings, and speeches, to a passive display of support for a cause on social networking sites, including posting, liking and sharing content as an everyday activity. Such passive demonstrations of activism take a nominal

cost to the partakers and still afford to own the positive feelings of the participants associated with participation in helping a cause.

The social movement carried out through digital means is qualitatively different from the traditional means of protest. Due to ubiquitous digital tools, e.g., producing, revising, and sharing Internet memes or hacking into a computer database, the social movement has made its presence felt online.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space provided below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

1. Explain the characteristics that define a social movement. How do these characteristics contribute to the effectiveness and impact of social movements in society?

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2. Classify social movements based on their objectives and scope. How do different types of social movements differ in their strategies and tactics for creating change?

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3. What is the social influence of digital media, and how does it shape public opinion? Discuss the role of social media platforms in amplifying voices and mobilising support for social causes.

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14.4 TYPES OF DIGITAL MEDIA ACTIVISM

Numerous similar terminologies are used to understand the role of digital media in social movements.

The use of digital media in activism is called Online activism, representing the digitally networked participation that covers natives' intended actions to raise awareness about or exert pressure on the government for a solution to political, social, and cultural matters. On the other hand, cyber-activism is an umbrella term for web-based forms of advocacy, including online awareness campaigns, web-based marketing for specific causes, and hacking. Digital

activism may encompass different forms such as 1) leaktivism (e.g., WikiLeaks), 2) hashtag activism (awareness promotion for any issue across several social media platforms)

Sandor Vegh (2013) classifies activism into communicative activism and techno-activism with an intent to manage the rising horde of online activism.

Communicative activism refers primarily to interactions among human beings, exchanges between them, and awareness-raising activities on social problems and issues. It includes mobilising and unifying people to act offline or online, for example, to participate in a street protest or to sign an e-petition. Communicative activism is the most common type of online activism that requires no sophisticated technical skills and usually occurs on widely available platforms, such as popular social networking or video-sharing sites.

By techno-activism refers to the actions of an individual to manipulate technological systems through programming bots and hacking a database. Data activism is another form of techno-activism that represents the manipulation and use of not widely available databases and makes them open with the intent to bring about a change in society. In comparison to communicative activism, techno-activism assumes the availability of net-based infrastructure and technological know-how, skills, and competencies of the users, which outdo an average Internet user.

Different forms of activism may be a combination of two or three variants of activism, e.g., a combination of communicative activism in blog posts and YouTube videos with data activism and social doxing, such as using public databases to identify and disclose assets and so on.

Passive activism is another widely used word to connote a form of digital activism limited to people talking and discussing issues on different social media platforms without any real visible change offline. Many criticise passive forms of resistance for not implying any direct effects, as people resort to criticism and censure a decision, policy, or system by being at home without facing the real situation.

Mind influencers have large followers on social media platforms such as Instagram, TikTok, and YouTube. Young folk often perceive them as role models, an epitome of beauty, success, and popularity. Mind influencers, by posting videos and memes in support of some views, can shape their followers' opinions and behaviour.

Cyberbullying/ trolling

Digital media provides a platform through which the voices of many can be amplified. However, the same voices can be directed against those who oppose them.

Users on digital media platforms are less inhibited than in real life. This is owing to an apparent reduction of concern about socially favourable self-presentation and the positive judgment of others. When using the Internet, the users reside in relative anonymity. They are physically safely distant from

others in interaction, often unaware of their identities and personalities and the negative consequences of risky or potentially damaging behaviours. Digital natives feel free to express anger or hatred through flaming, hostile comments, insults, name-calling, cursing, and so on.

Virtual sit-ins are a form of online protest in which digital media activists or the networked community of protesters gather on one or several sites to act out digital dissent. Conducted online, protestors' automated clicking simultaneously performed through several computers worldwide inhibit or halt the target website's traffic. Protesters worldwide send repetitive requests to the targeted web pages that jam the bandwidth, decelerate the site's visibility, and eventually cause the targeted website to shut down.

14.4.1 Channels of Communication In Digital Activism

With the growth of digital media, various forms of activism have been actively employed by activists. Social media activist mostly uses digital media for posting, debating, and sharing relevant information online and mobilising and coordinating movement-related actions. It is now easier for an activist to set up an event site on Facebook, create a group, and stream videos of protest and antagonism.

Channels of communication in digital activism represent various forms of digital media usage, which include filing online petitions, a member participating in online communities, hosting campaign websites, podcasting the protest, writing a blog on the cause about the problems and solutions, taking part in internet bulletin boards, streaming protest videos on YouTube and so on.

- Websites online petitions: a form of petition signed online, usually through a form on a website. People and organisations can communicate about their cause by signing the petition and adding details of the problem, solution, and action; for example, iPetitions and change.org allow users to create and sign petitions to advance various social causes by raising awareness and influencing decision-makers.
- Blogs are simple web pages consisting of brief paragraphs of opinion, information, personal diary entries, or links called posts that provide an effective communication platform to spread the cause of the social movement.
- Web proxy servers: These servers act as an intermediary between a user and a site they browse and protect the user from being identified. Online protesters use web proxy servers to avail government interventions in online activism.
- Social networks like Facebook, social media comprising WhatsApp and YouTube, and microblogging sites like Twitter and many more have upheld the support for a cause by sharing and spreading messages. Here, people of the same interest discuss the issues in detail. Activists use arrays of tools such as page likes groups/ forums/ even pages for sharing and subscription, changing profile or cover photo, sarcastic comments/ status, and live streaming for showing solidarity and dissent.

- Sukey is a Web app that opens a line of dialogue between protesters and the authorities and keeps activists safe, mobile, and informed during a demonstration. Sukey, a tool that combines Google Maps and open-source software like SwiftRiver, developed by a U.K. uncut activist, provided an avenue for the protesters to follow the actions of the activists in the U.K.
- Likewise, Ushahidi software is used to plot disaster zones like earthquakes in Haiti and New Zealand and floods in Australia and the U.S.A.

14.4.2 Digital Activism as Connective Action

Lance Bennett and Alexandra Segerberg (2012) theorised the role of digital media in social movement as connective action. In contrast to earlier social movements or traditional collective action, the new social movement has given primacy to using digital media that can offer connective variety. The members of the old-style social movement are inspired by an ideology they share with their followers. The ideology is the binding force of the collective members and, similarly, the guiding force to coordinate social action in a top-down manner.

Net-based online connective action may be expressed by sharing ideas, advocating a cause, sharing memes, online petitions, etc. The net-based online connective action aids the participants to easily find their own tailored action, which may be their ticket to activism without adhering to a clear-cut ideology. There are chances when volunteers and supporters only get a vague idea about the actual cause online. Even the grassroots actions of the volunteers are not dictated from above, yet there is room for ingenuity and creativity in the expression of views online.

Bennett and Segerberg (2012) elucidated two basic forms of connective action.

1. Self-organising grassroots-oriented network-based action that is mobilised horizontally by internet users via digital media without a central coordinating organisation.
2. Organizationally enabled networks when there is an organisation coordinating action in the background yet providing scope for users to find their ways to participate.

In crowdfunding instances of activism, e.g., initiatives conducted through change.org, there is usually little or no organisational coordination since the action consists of donating money through a convenient online platform. On the other hand, there are instances of hierarchical organisation coordinates with a horizontally networked group of volunteers.

14.5 SOCIAL MOVEMENT THROUGH DIGITAL MEDIA: GLOBAL TRENDS

One of the major and most noteworthy international social movements that

have benefitted from the use of the Internet is the anti-globalisation movement of 1994. Known by the Zapatista rebellion in southern Mexico, this internet-induced movement brings together various organisations and individuals and coordinates an online solidarity network worldwide. Zapatista rebels instituted an official Zapatista website at Swarthmore College web server in the United States. In 1995, many email lists circulated among the supporters of the movement, along with the various anonymous websites promoting the Zapatista cause. Using the Internet helped the Zapatista create a national and international base where leaders could seek feedback from their supporters. Email communication was key to the logistical and political planning of intercontinental meetings in the Zapatista rebellion. Internet and email help grassroots activists coordinate the movement activities across some forty countries.

Global trends in the use of digital media for social movement cover the Battle of Seattle, 1999 in the United States; the WikiLeaks disclosures of the U.S. State Department; the 'Ice bucket challenge' of Amyotrophic Lateral Sclerosis (A.L.S.) Association and the Kony 2012 are some of the popular net-initiated social movements.

The Coffee Party first appeared on the social networking site Facebook on January 26, 2010, through the Join Coffee Party movement fan page. The Facebook collective grew in size to over 200000 fans by April 2010 through word of mouth within six weeks. The party continues its membership and support through file-sharing sites, such as Flickr.

Social networking sites (S.N.S.) are used for mobilisation during Iranian election protests. Using sites such as Twitter and Facebook, Iranians could organise and voice against the election of Mahmoud Ahmadinejad. S.N.S. have made it quicker and easier for large numbers of people in a collective for a helping cause. This, in turn, prompted widespread government censorship of the web and social networking sites. Using new communication technologies provides a better platform for new social movements.

The Philippine 'Smart Mob' of 2001 is an example of the use of mobile phones by the Philippine population, removing President Joseph Estrada. Less than two hours after the decision was announced, thousands of angry Filipinos converged in Manila and demanded the resignation of the corrupt president. The protesters stood for the cause of expelling Estrada through mobile text messages. In a week, a record of seven million messages were sent.

The Arab Spring, the popular uprisings in the Middle East since 2011, is another classic example of a social movement that used digital media. Owing to the slow pace of change in the Middle East for forty years or more, the desire for democratic reforms and freedoms in the region had brewed up. The desperate act of a 26-year-old street vendor, Mohamed Bouazizi, who set himself on fire in Tunisia in December 2011, prompted the astounding chain of events extended to neighbouring states.

The conflict in Darfur is described diversely as "genocide" and "war," spurring the moral crusade in the digital media platform. The Save Darfur

Cause was one of the largest Causes on Facebook, mobilising a collective donation of \$100,000 from more than 1 million members.

In February 2003, millions worldwide were mobilised to protest against the Bush administration's drive for war against Iraq. Another example is the Egyptian revolution of January- February 2011. Thousands of protestors and youth decided through online methods to meet at Cairo's Tahir Square to protest against the high-handedness of President Hosni Mubarak of Egypt and his regime, which was brawled with corruption, electoral fraud, unemployment, and a state of emergency. The digital media eventually aided in the overthrow of the Mubarak Government.

Taiwan protest is another incident of digital activism when students occupy parliament buildings in Taipei of Taiwan to protest against their government's trade pact with China. Students in Taiwan use a newly released app, fireChat, to send messages from one phone to another, even without an internet connection. Hundreds of online protests occur yearly, aiming at issues focused on corruption, social justice, power abuse, and so on.

14.5.1 Hashtag Activism

Being merely a recent origin, the term hashtag activism aims to raise awareness of social issues and encourage debates via hashtags on social media. The hashtag has been a powerful social media tool that can be easily used without restriction. It represents and establishes equal participation of all in the online world. A hashtag refers to supporting a cause on a social media platform. The hashtag or symbol "#" becomes an integral part of social media that signifies broad themes. The hashtag is first initiated on Twitter by the users to tag posts of a specific cluster of people, topics, or discussion and themes. It is a user-generated practice that categorises debate, discussion, and trending topics on Twitter. It is also used on Twitter or any other social media platform to plan protests and boycotts, share stories, discussions, and political topics, and ultimately drive social change.

Hashtags categorise information and contribute to the co-creation of meaning by emphasising their performative or constitutional character.

By linking topics or information, hashtag activism establishes relations between various actors. It offers multi-vocal and multi-perspective discourse formation, contributing to different perspectives and creating or reproducing relationships between actors.

Empirical accounts of hashtag activism have focused on minority rights or human rights debates, such as # LGBT rights, #BlackLivesMatter, and #MeToo. #Blacklivematter is a social calling card for social justice and racial equality activists across the U.S. to raise awareness about anti-black racism and police violence. #BlackOutSopa was introduced in October 2011 as a protest against the Stop Online Piracy Act.

#FridaysForFuture, a protest carried out in 2018 by Greta Thunberg, a 15-year-old who stood every day in front of the Swedish parliament for three weeks in response to the lack of action to address the climate crisis.

Similarly, the Ice Bucket Challenge was another popular digital activism to promote awareness about amyotrophic lateral sclerosis A.L.S. and raised donations for research.

Following the travel ban on the seven Muslim-majority nations by U.S. President Trump, Iranians started a social media campaign with the hashtag #LoveBeyondFlags on social media to share their messages.

Moreover, social media users expressed their solidarity through hashtag activism, e.g., #Paris attacks #PrayforParis by protesting against two major terrorist attacks in Paris.

14.5.2 Digital Media Activism: Indian Experiences

The permeating nature of digital mobile devices and easy access to online social media platforms support activists to share content and express their experiences and concerns. Communication in digital media facilitates large crowds to work together without needing leaders and an organisation for collective action. With the Internet and mobile growth, digital activism spread in developing nations like India. Digital media provides a platform for activists to voice their opinions and empowers political groups to propagate political campaigns more efficiently than ever before.

In India, digital activism tools were used during the movement of Anna Hazare, when civil society pursued to challenge the government's secrecy. Netizens shared posts, arranged mass agitation on the streets, and forced the government to pass the Lokpal Bill, India against corruption.

Digital activism turned into a political tool in the possession of Arvind Kejriwal, presently Delhi Chief Minister, who used the affordance of social media tools to control public dissent.

Further, the Narendra Modi Government is using digital tools with various social media affordances during his political rallies and campaigns to win the Lok Sabha elections in 2014 and 2019. Prime Minister Modi joined Twitter in 2019 and became the most followed politician after previous U.S. President Barack Obama and current U.S. President Donald Trump.

Digital activism turned into a social tool for mass dissent in 2012 against the atrocious crime of rape, which involves a young girl who was raped in a moving bus in New Delhi; later, she succumbed to death. The incident led to public outrage, and people came to the streets against the crime. Social media, primarily Facebook and Twitter, built solidarity for the issue with a hashtag campaign in the name of Nirbhaya Damini. People even changed their profile pictures on social media to black as a mark of protest. This protest pressurises the government to take legislative action to protect women, along with the provision for severe punishment for the heinous crime of rape committed against women.

Protest and debates continue over the gang rape of a 19-year-old girl in Hathras district of Uttar Pradesh, a case that created turmoil on social media with trending hashtags – #hathrashorror, #hathrascase #hathrashorrorshock India.

In 2006, the meToo Movement took the world glare with the Harvey Weinstein Scandal in the U.S.A. The meToo was initiated by the social activist Tarana Burke. It inspired many women to open up and narrate their stories of abuse and sexual harassment by the men in power. The meToo is an online resistant movement that protests and challenges the patriarchal structure of society, shaming and humiliating people who dishonoured them in the past. The meToo in India gathered momentum with Bollywood actress Tanushree Dutta's stand against the abuse of her male co-star. The incident prompted other women to come out narrating their own # MeToo stories.

#LahuKaLagaan was another popular hashtag campaign in India, a form of movement through digital means launched by She Says, a women's rights organisation, for making sanitary napkins easily accessible and tax-free, and eventually filed a P.I.L. before the Bombay High Court.

Another hashtag activism, #NotInMyName, initiated by Saba Dewan, an Indian filmmaker, protested against the lynching of Muslims and Dalits in India, following which people participated in a silent pan-Indian protest rally.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space provided below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of the unit.

1. How does digital media contribute to the formation of public opinion? Analyse the impact of online information consumption and echo chambers on forming public attitudes and beliefs.

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2. Explore the role of Web 2.0 tools in fostering digital activism. How do these tools enable individuals and groups to advocate, collaborate, and amplify their messages?

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3. Compare hashtag activism with other forms of digital media activism. Assess the effectiveness of hashtag campaigns in raising awareness and driving social change with reference to global trends and Indian experiences.

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14.6 LET US SUM UP

Digital media provides ample scope for many activists to work anonymously. We have discussed how citizens carried out demonstrations using digital media technologies, e.g., social networking websites and cell phones, to invoke public support and circumvent state controls. The ability of digital media to connect instantly has transformed how relationships are created and maintained and altered the very structure of our social fabric. Digital media creates unprecedented prospects for information flow, emotional expression, social influence, and even independent democratic revolution.

However, digital media allows for an extreme form of narrowcasting and information filtering that might go against the interests of civil society.

From this unit, we have understood the concept of social movement, its elements, characteristics, and classification. We have also understood the concept of digital media activism and the influence of web2.0 tools on activists and their role in creating complementary practices of digital media activism. The unit has further drawn in the emerging trends in activism and how various digital platforms are used as communication channels in activism. The unit also discusses hashtag activism, a recent phenomenon in some contemporary online activism cases. The unit concluded by deliberating upon some cases on the global trends in activism alongside the Indian experiences of digital media activism.

14.7 FURTHER READING

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14.8 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

1. Social movements are collective, organised efforts that aim to bring about social change. Characteristics like collective identity, shared grievances, and mobilisation enhance their impact by uniting people around a common cause and advocating for change through various means.
2. Social movements can be classified as reformist, revolutionary, redemptive, or alternative based on their objectives and scope. Each type employs distinct strategies and tactics, ranging from incremental reforms to radical transformations, to achieve their goals.
3. Digital media exerts significant social influence by facilitating the rapid dissemination of information and enabling real-time interactions. Social media platforms are crucial in shaping public opinion by promoting discussions, sharing diverse perspectives, and facilitating collective action around social issues.

Check Your Progress 2

1. Digital media influences public opinion by providing access to diverse information sources. However, online echo chambers and algorithms prioritising personalised content can lead to information bubbles, potentially reinforcing existing beliefs and limiting exposure to diverse viewpoints.
2. Web 2.0 tools, such as social networking sites and online platforms, empower digital activists to engage in advocacy and collaborate globally. These tools facilitate information sharing, mobilisation, and organising, enabling activists to effectively reach broader audiences and amplify their messages.
3. Hashtag activism leverages social media hashtags to draw attention to specific causes and mobilise support. While it can raise awareness and garner widespread attention quickly, its long-term impact depends on sustained engagement and offline action. The effectiveness of hashtag campaigns varies based on factors like platform reach, public engagement, and the synergy between online and offline efforts.